



ACC PREVIEW



PREDICTED ORDER OF FINISH

	1	MIAMI HURRICANES
	2	SMU MUSTANGS
	3	LOUISVILLE CARDINALS
	4	CLEMSON TIGERS
	5	VIRGINIA TECH HOKIES
	6	VIRGINIA CAVALIERS
	7	PITT PANTHERS
	8	GEORGIA TECH YELLOW JACKETS
	9	NC STATE WOLFPACK
	10	CAL GOLDEN BEARS
	11	FLORIDA STATE SEMINOLES
	12	WAKE FOREST DEMON DEACONS
	13	DUKE BLUE DEVILS
	14	NORTH CAROLINA TAR HEELS
	15	SYRACUSE ORANGE
	16	BOSTON COLLEGE EAGLES
	17	STANFORD CARDINAL

ACC CHAMPIONSHIP

MIAMI OVER SMU



JOIN COLLEGE FOOTBALL EXPERT STEVEN LASSAN AT ATHLONSPORTS.COM FOR A LOOK AT SECOND- AND THIRD-TEAM SELECTIONS

ALL-ACC TEAM

FIRST-TEAM OFFENSE

QB	DARIAN MENSAH	Miami (Fla.)
RB	ISAAC BROWN	Louisville
RB	MARK FLETCHER JR.	Miami (Fla.)
AP	MALACHI TONEY	Miami (Fla.)
WR	DUCE ROBINSON	Florida State
WR	COOPER BARKATE	Miami (Fla.)
WR	BRYANT WESCO JR.	Clemson
TE	LUKE REYNOLDS	Virginia Tech
C	JOSHUA BATES	SMU
OL	PJ WILLIAMS	SMU
OL	McKALE BOLEY	Virginia
OL	LANCE ROBINSON	Louisville
OL	ETHAN MACKENNY	Georgia Tech

FIRST-TEAM DEFENSE

DL	DAMON WILSON II	Miami (Fla.)
DL	CLEV LUBIN	Louisville
DL	WILL HELDT	Clemson
DL	MELKART ABOU JAOUDE	North Carolina
LB	SAMMY BROWN	Clemson
LB	MATT ROSE	Stanford
LB	BRAYLAN LOVELACE	Pitt
LB	KAM ROBINSON	Virginia
DB	ASHTON HAMPTON	Clemson
DB	TAYON HOLLOWAY	Louisville
DB	BRYCE FITZGERALD	Miami (Fla.)
DB	CHRIS PEAL	Syracuse

FIRST-TEAM SPECIALISTS

K	AIDAN BIRR	Georgia Tech
P	DYLAN JOYCE	Miami (Fla.)
KR	TRE RICHARDSON	Louisville
PR	MALACHI TONEY	Miami (Fla.)

BOWL PROJECTIONS

Gasparilla: Georgia Tech vs. Memphis

First Responder: Cal vs. Washington State

Military: Wake Forest vs. Temple

Pinstripe: Pitt vs. Minnesota

Fenway: NC State vs. Army

Pop-Tarts: Louisville vs. Houston

Gator: SMU vs. Alabama

Sun: Virginia vs. Utah

Duke's Mayo: Virginia Tech vs. Tennessee

Holiday: Clemson vs. Washington

College Football Playoff First Round: Miami (Fla.) vs. LSU

COORDINATOR CAROUSEL

BOSTON COLLEGE

Offense: New: Bill O'Brien; Old: Will Lawing

Defense: New: Ted Roof; Old: Tim Lewis

CAL

Offense: New: Jordan Somerville, Ike Hilliard; Old: Bryan Harsin

Defense: New: Michael Hutchings, Da'Von Brown; Old: Vic So'oto, Terrence Brown

CLEMSON

Offense: New: Chad Morris

Old: Garrett Riley

FLORIDA STATE

Offense: New: Mike Norvell, Tim Harris Jr.; Old: Gus Malzahn

GEORGIA TECH

Offense: New: George Godsey, Chris Weinke; Old: Buster Faulkner

Defense: New: Jason Semore
Old: Blake Gideon

LOUISVILLE

Defense: New: Mark Ivey, Steve Ellis

Old: Ron English, Mark Hagen

NORTH CAROLINA

Offense: New: Bobby Petrino

Old: Freddie Kitchens

PITT

Defense: New: Cory Sanders

Old: Randy Bates

SMU

Offense: New: Garin Justice, D'Eriq King; Old: Casey Woods

Defense: New: Maurice Crum Jr., Rickey Hunley Jr.; Old: Scott Symons

STANFORD

Offense: New: Terry Heffernan

Old: Nate Byham

Defense: New: Kris Richard

Old: Bobby April, Andy Thompson

SYRACUSE

Defense: New: Vince Kehres, John Scott Jr.; Old: Elijah Robinson, Robert Wright

VIRGINIA TECH

Offense: New: Ty Howle

Old: Philip Montgomery

Defense: New: Brent Pry

Old: Sam Siefkes

TOP 10 RECRUITS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
1. Jackson Cantwell	OT	Miami (Fla.)	★★★★★	3
2. Somourian Wingo	WR	Miami (Fla.)	★★★★	37
3. Naeem Burroughs	WR	Clemson	★★★★	42
4. Gavin Mueller	TE	Miami (Fla.)	★★★★	45
5. Asharri Charles	EDGE	Miami (Fla.)	★★★★	85



BRAYLAN LOVELACE, PITT
DARIAN MENSAH, MIAMI (FLA.)



TOP TRANSFERS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	FORMER SCHOOL
1. Darian Mensah	QB	Miami (Fla.)	Duke
Mensah led the ACC in passing, and his supporting cast will be even better.			
2. Damon Wilson II	DL	Miami (Fla.)	Missouri
UM needs pass rush production, and here comes Wilson fresh off a nine-sack season.			
3. Cooper Barkate	WR	Miami (Fla.)	Duke
Barkate followed Mensah south after his second consecutive 1,000-yard season.			
4. Ethan Grunkemeyer	QB	Virginia Tech	Penn State
Grunkemeyer follows head coach James Franklin to the ACC.			
5. Justice Haynes	RB	Georgia Tech	Michigan
Haynes is a big-play back with a nose for the end zone.			
6. Lincoln Kienholz	QB	Louisville	Ohio State
The Cardinals went back to the portal for their QB and betting on a blue-chip talent.			
7. Luke Reynolds	TE	Virginia Tech	Penn State
Reynolds is a former 5-star recruit who followed Franklin to Blacksburg.			
8. Que'Sean Brown	WR	Virginia Tech	Duke
Brown broke out last season and could become Grunkemeyer's go-to target.			
9. Tre Richardson	WR	Louisville	Vanderbilt
Richardson was among the best deep-threat options in the SEC in his FBS debut.			
10. Ian Strong	WR	Cal	Rutgers
Strong has the size (6-foot-4) and skill to win on the outside.			

RECRUITING RANKINGS BY SCHOOL

1. Miami (Fla.) (7)	6. SMU (31)	11. NC State (40)
2. Florida State (16)	7. Virginia Tech (33)	12. Louisville (46)
3. North Carolina (21)	8. Syracuse (36)	13. Pitt (55)
4. Clemson (22)	9. Stanford (38)	14. Boston College (56)
5. Wake Forest (29)	10. Georgia Tech (39)	15. Cal (57)
		16. Duke (78)
		17. Virginia (113)

Rankings per Rivals; National ranking in parentheses

GAMES TO WATCH

Sept. 5 Clemson at LSU

Sept. 6 Louisville vs. Ole Miss (Nashville)

Sept. 19 SMU at Louisville

Oct. 3 Miami (Fla.) at Clemson

Oct. 31 Clemson at Florida State

Nov. 7 Louisville at Georgia Tech

Nov. 7 Virginia Tech at SMU

Nov. 7 Miami (Fla.) at Notre Dame

Nov. 20 Virginia Tech at Miami (Fla.)

Nov. 21 SMU at Notre Dame

Nov. 28 Virginia at Virginia Tech

Nov. 28 South Carolina at Clemson

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
6. Keshawn Stancil	DL	Miami (Fla.)	★★★★	91
7. Kenton Dopson III	CB	North Carolina	★★★★	94
8. Milan Parris	WR	Miami (Fla.)	★★★★	109
9. Izayah Williams	LB	Florida State	★★★★	116
10. Earnest Rankins	DL	Florida State	★★★★	125

Rankings per Rivals; +Consensus 5-star prospect



BOSTON COLLEGE EAGLES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 83 | ACC PREDICTION: 16 | 2025 RECORD: 2-10, 1-7 ACC

OFFENSE Boston College will look to reverse a horrific 2025 season in which head coach Bill O'Brien's squad went 2-10. While the team got hit with an avalanche of major injuries, there were problems up and down the roster.

The Eagles lost two of their key weapons with running back Turbo Richard (Indiana) and wide receiver Reed Harris (Arizona State) leaving via the portal. BC added Great Lakes Intercollegiate Athletic Conference Player of the Year QB Mason McKenzie out of Div. II Saginaw Valley State; he is the presumed starting quarterback. Running back Evan Dickens arrives from Liberty, and a half-dozen offensive linemen, many of whom are in position to start, have transferred in.

Tight end Kaelan Chudzinski (24 receptions, 313 yards, four TDs) was a revelation last season, and if he continues to develop, he could become one of the best tight ends in the ACC.

DEFENSE On defense, KP Price, BC's leading defensive player from '25 returns, giving BC a hard-hitting and smart safety who can focus on his position instead of being moved around because of injuries.

The Eagles also did a very solid job rebuilding their edge rusher position in the portal, adding Kris Jones (Georgia) and Demetrius Ballard (Buffalo). O'Brien also turned to the portal to fill his linebacker spots, adding three LBs who figure to get major snaps this year: Bodie Kahoun (Notre Dame), Anthony Palano (Washington State) and Justin Medlock (SMU).

SPECIALISTS The special teams unit returns arguably BC's best player in 2025 — placekicker Luca Lombardo, who connected on 16-of-17 field-goal attempts. FCS Towson transfer Bryce LaFollette is likely to be the starting punter, while starting defensive backs TJ Green and Isaiah Farris are slated for return duties.

FINAL ANALYSIS O'Brien's coaching staff is almost completely revamped, with veteran coach Ted Roof taking the defensive reins and O'Brien and some of his assistants handling offensive play-calling. In all, O'Brien replaced 75% of his positional staff during the offseason.

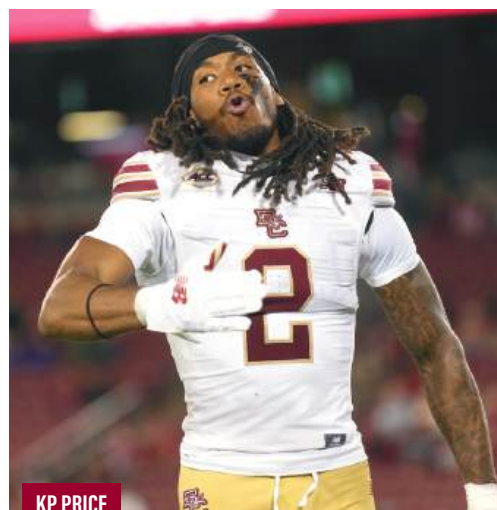
BC also saw the most active transfer portal period in school history, as 30 players departed, and 28 transfers arrived.

This year could have a host of different outcomes, depending on how the transfers perform. If McKenzie can be a mobile game-changer like Ole Miss star Trinidad Chambliss, to whom O'Brien has compared him, BC could be a surprise team. But if McKenzie struggles, and a new offensive line does not jell, this could be another long season in Chestnut Hill.

2025 RESULTS (2-10, 1-7 ACC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Fordham	W	66-10	Sept. 5	at Cincinnati	1.	Demetrius Thompson, EDGE ★★
Sept. 6	at Michigan State (ot)	L	40-42	Sept. 11	Rutgers	2.	Mason Leak, EDGE ★★
Sept. 13	at Stanford	L	20-30	Sept. 19	Maine	3.	Marcelino Antunes Jr., OT ★★
Sept. 27	California	L	24-28	Sept. 26	Virginia Tech	4.	Femi Babalola, QB ★★
Oct. 4	at Pittsburgh	L	7-48	Oct. 3	at SMU	5.	Jordan Rodriguez, S ★★
Oct. 11	Clemson	L	10-41	Oct. 17	Pitt	6.	Gerald Green Jr., CB ★★
Oct. 18	UConn	L	23-38	Oct. 24	at Georgia Tech	7.	Marek Jin, IOL ★★
Oct. 25	at Louisville	L	24-38	Oct. 31	at Duke	8.	Steve Klein, LB ★★
Nov. 1	Notre Dame	L	10-25	Nov. 7	Florida State	9.	Kelvin Brown Jr., WR ★★
Nov. 8	SMU	L	13-45	Nov. 14	at Notre Dame	10.	DJ Biggins, WR ★★
Nov. 15	Georgia Tech	L	34-36	Nov. 21	Syracuse		
Nov. 29	at Syracuse	W	34-12	Nov. 28	at Miami (Fla.)		

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Bill O'Brien - Record at School: 9-16 (2 years) - Career Record: 24-25 (4 years) - Offensive Coordinator: Bill O'Brien
Defensive Coordinator: Ted Roof - Location: Chestnut Hill, Mass. - Stadium: Alumni Stadium (44,500)



KP PRICE

SCOUTING THE EAGLES

"[Bill O'Brien] is an excellent coach. They just don't have any playmakers. When that place has been good, it's always been good quarterback play, and they could run the football, really good tight ends, which they do have one now with Kaelan Chudzinski. He's a really good player, but they don't have a lot of really dynamic play-makers. I know that they brought in a couple of transfers at quarterback, but I don't know if any of them are elite players. ... Zay Flowers is the only receiver that Boston College has had drafted in the last 30 years, but as a recruit, he was a peanut who ended up being an incredible player. They're not gonna out-recruit anyone at receiver. Ever."

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (1)

WR	1	Jaedn Skeete (Jr.)	4	Javarius Green* (So.)
WR	3	Dawson Pough (So.)	14	Nedrick Boldin Jr. (Fr.)
WR	8	Johnathan Montague Jr. (So.)	80	Reed Swanson* (Jr.)
LT	75	Pape Abdoulaye Sy (So.)	63	Veguer Jean-Jumeau* (So.)
LG	71	Kristian Phillips* (Sr.)	56	Jani Norwood* (So.)
C	77	MICHAEL CROUNSE (JR.)	50	Owen Snively* (Sr.)
RG	55	Robert Smith IV (So.)	52	Judah Pruitt (So.)
RT	70	Reggie Jackson* (Jr.)	53	Trevon Humphrey* (Sr.)
TE	85	Kaelan Chudzinski (So.)	87	Cameron Kossman* (Fr.)
QB	10	Mason McKenzie* (Jr.)	15	Grayson Wilson* (Fr.)
RB	23	Evan Dickens* (Jr.)	2	Nolan Ray* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	8	Onye Nwosisi (Sr.)	48	Bryce Lewis (Fr.)
DT	90	KJ Sampson* (Jr.)	59	Micah Amedee (So.)
DT	6	CHRIS MARABLE JR. (JR.)	55	Christian Hudson* (So.)
DE	4	Kris Jones* (So.)	41	Favor Bate (Jr.)
LB	16	Anthony Palano* (So.)	36	Bodie Kahoun* (Fr.)
LB	20	Justin Medlock* (Sr.)	43	Griffin Collins (So.)
CB	0	TJ Green (So.)	29	Cameron Martinez (Sr.)
CB	3	Max Tucker (Sr.)	14	Ashton Cunningham (So.)
CB	10	Syair Torrence (So.)	19	Marcelous Townsend (Fr.)
S	2	KP PRICE (SR.)	18	Kameron Howard* (Jr.)
S	7	CARTER DAVIS (JR.)	5	Marcus Upton (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	99	Luca Lombardo (Sr.)	KR	0	TJ Green (So.)
P		Bryce LaFollette* (Sr.)	PR	1	Isaiah Farris (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

DARREN YAMASHITA-IMAGN IMAGES



JARON-KEAWE SAGAPOLUTELE

SCOUTING THE GOLDEN BEARS

"I think they did a great job with this new staff. They have a great grasp of what they want for the future. It's a great alumni base. With them being able to get [quarterback Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele] to return, that just shows their commitment to winning. Putting the right players around him, they can make a run in the ACC. I'm not saying they're gonna be able to win the ACC, but they're gonna have a chance to hang around just because of the quarterback play. The guys around him will rise to his level. ... Their recruiting guy, Marshall Cherrington, is as good as they get in the industry. He's incredibly well-respected, a phenomenal evaluator. He's the best networker I've ever been around. He's an absolute superstar in every facet."

—An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	9	Ian Strong* (Sr.)	15	Mark Hamper (Jr.)
WR	7	Chase Hendricks* (Sr.)	82	Cole Boscia (Sr.)
WR	10	Cooper Perry* (So.)	19	Trevor Rogers (So.)
LT	77	Jimothy Lewis Jr.* (So.)	54	Frederick Williams III (Jr.)
LG	71	SIOAPE VATIKANI (SR.)	58	Ashton Rivera* (Jr.)
C	76	Bastian Swinney (Sr.)	78	Lamar Robinson (Sr.)
RG	56	TYSON RUFFINS (JR.)	78	Lamar Robinson (Sr.)
RT	51	Kahlee Tafai* (Jr.)	75	Jacob Arop* (So.)
TE	0	Dorian Thomas* (Jr.)	85	MASON MINI (JR.)
QB	3	JARON-KEAWE SAGAPOLUTELE (SO.)	11	Jackson Brousseau* (Jr.)
RB	24	Adam Mohammed* (Jr.)	20	Ashten Emory* (So.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	98	NATE BURRELL (SR.)	56	Legend Journey (So.)
DT	44	Jericho Johnson* (So.)	99	Ashun Sheppard* (Sr.)
DT	96	Dereke Wilkins (Sr.)	94	Stanley Saale-McKenzie (Sr.)
DE	0	Solomon Williams* (So.)	6	Emmanuel Okoye* (So.)
LB	32	Tristan Jernigan* (So.)	4	Justin Beadles* (Sr.)
LB	21	Aaron Hampton (Jr.)	3	Kamar Mothudi* (So.)
CB	1	Ricky Fletcher* (Sr.)	8	Jasiah Wagoner (Jr.)
CB	7	Daniel Harris* (Sr.)	13	Jae'on Young (Fr.)
NB	20	CAM SIDNEY (SR.)	26	Niles Davis (Fr.)
S	2	Kingston Lopa* (So.)	23	Isaiah Crosby (Jr.)
S	14	AIDEN MANUTAI (SO.)	16	Michael Hurst Jr.* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	91	Chase Meyer (Sr.)	KR	19	Trevor Rogers (So.)
P	29	Angus Davies* (Sr.)	PR	7	Chase Hendricks* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN **BOLD** • *2026 TRANSFER



CAL GOLDEN BEARS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 47 | ACC PREDICTION: 10 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 4-4 ACC

OFFENSE New Cal head coach Tosh Lupoi left his introductory news conference, flew to Hawai'i, convinced star quarterback Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele to return and then flew back, without changing clothes. Lupoi has a potential centerpiece in JKS, and he's not taking him for granted.

The Bears are building around Sagapolutele with gifted wide receivers, tight ends and running backs while working to upgrade the offensive line. Cal added second-team All-MAC wideout Chase Hendricks (Ohio), productive Rutgers receiver Ian Strong and New Mexico's Dorian Thomas, a first-team All-Mountain West selection who ranked among the nation's top-10 tight ends for receptions (56) and receiving yards (560).

Cal has depth at tight end with returning starter Mason Mini, Purdue transfer Rico Walker and others. Washington transfer Adam Mohammed, who rushed for 105 yards against Lupoi's Oregon defense in 2025, headlines a transfer-heavy running back room.

The line returns experience in the interior with Tyson Ruffins and Sioape Vatikani, and Cal has supplemented with transfers, as Jimothy Lewis Jr. (Mississippi State), Kahlee Tafai (Minnesota) and others arrive.

DEFENSE Lupoi and the defensive staff have work ahead to transform body types, including adding length up front. Veterans Nate Burrell and Derek Wilkins return, and tackle Jericho Johnson is among those who joined Lupoi from Oregon. Cal also is banking on potential with edge transfers Solomon Williams (Texas A&M) and Emmanuel Okoye (Tennessee).

Linebacker is a question as first-team All-ACC selection Cade Uluave and Luke Ferrelli, the ACC Defensive Freshman of the Year, both transferred. Aaron Hampton and Jayden Wayne are back, but Cal will need to fill out the depth chart with transfers like Texas A&M's Tristan Jernigan.

Cal's secondary has a new look, but "we upgraded dramatically there, as far as size-speed combo," Lupoi says. The length shows up at cornerback with 6-foot-3 Ole Miss transfer Ricky Fletcher, 6-foot-3 Georgia transfer Daniel Harris and others. Nickel Cam Sidney returns from 2025.

SPECIALISTS Chase Meyer is back after connecting on 10-of-13 field goals, including 7-of-7 inside 40 yards. Cal added punter Angus Davies from Tulsa in the portal. Jacob De Jesus will be missed on returns, and special teams coordinator Zach Tinker likely will lean on Hendricks and others.

FINAL ANALYSIS Lupoi and general manager Ron Rivera bring a pedal-down personnel approach that Cal needs. If Sagapolutele gets better protection, he could lead one of the ACC's better passing attacks. Cal lost key back-end players on defense and must generally get better along both lines of scrimmage, but the future looks bright.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 4-4 ACC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30	at Oregon State	W	34-15	Sept. 5	UCLA	1. Taimane Purcell, TE ★★★★★
Sept. 6	Texas Southern	W	35-3	Sept. 12	at Syracuse	2. Daniel McMorris, OT ★★★★★
Sept. 13	Minnesota	W	27-14	Sept. 19	Wagner	3. EJ Morgan, WR ★★★★★
Sept. 20	at San Diego State	L	0-34	Sept. 25	Clemson	4. Nainoa Lopes, QB ★★★★★
Sept. 27	at Boston College	W	28-24	Oct. 3	at UNLV	5. Victor Santino, RB ★★★★★
Oct. 4	Duke	L	21-45	Oct. 10	Virginia Tech	6. Jaxon Pyatt, LB ★★★★★
Oct. 17	North Carolina	W	21-18	Oct. 17	Wake Forest	7. Elisha Faamatuainu, IOL ★★★★★
Oct. 24	at Virginia Tech (ot)	L	34-42	Oct. 24	at SMU	8. Kamo'i Huihui-White, IOL ★★★★★
Nov. 1	Virginia	L	21-31	Oct. 31	at NC State	9. JD McKinley, LB ★★★★★
Nov. 8	at Louisville (ot)	W	29-26	Nov. 14	at Virginia	10. Nemyah Telona, DL ★★★★★
Nov. 22	at Stanford	L	10-31	Nov. 21	Stanford	
Nov. 29	SMU	W	38-35	Nov. 28	Pitt	
Dec. 24	vs. Hawai'i #	L	31-35			
			#Hawai'i Bowl			
TEAM INFORMATION						
Head Coach: Tosh Lupoi • Record at School: First Season • Career Record: First Season • Offensive Coordinators: Jordan Somerville, Ike Hilliard						
Defensive Coordinators: Michael Hutchings, DaVon Brown • Location: Berkeley, Calif. Stadium: California Memorial Stadium (63,000)						



CLEMSON TIGERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 27 | ACC PREDICTION: 4 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 4-4 ACC

OFFENSE Quarterback Christopher Vizzina spent three years as Cade Klubnik's backup. Now, the former top-100 recruit from Alabama is the favorite to start in 2026. Vizzina has limited experience (105 career pass attempts), but he was solid in his first career start last season vs. SMU. If Vizzina struggles, Clemson could turn to true freshman Tait Reynolds.

At wide receiver, juniors T.J. Moore and Bryant Wesco Jr. are both future pros and lead a deep, talented group. Gideon Davidson and SMU transfer Chris Johnson Jr. provide a strong 1-2 punch at running back, and Clemson has good options at tight end, led by Olsen Patt-Henry.

The Tigers must replace three of their five primary offensive line starters from last year. The unit as a whole is seeking more consistency and explosiveness under Chad Morris, who's back for his second stint as Clemson's offensive coordinator after a successful run from 2011-14.

DEFENSE Transfers are the name of the game for Clemson's defense, which will enter 2026 with a seven portal players on the defense's two-deep. Their job? Add competitive depth and speed to a Tigers defense that didn't have enough talent across the board last year.

Players like Elliot Washington II (Penn State), London Merritt (Colorado), Corey Myrick (Southern Miss) and Jerome Carter III (Old Dominion) should see immediate reps for Clemson, which lost seven 2025 defensive starters to either the NFL Draft or the transfer portal.

Junior linebacker Sammy Brown and senior defensive end Will Heldt — a former Purdue transfer who turned down a draft opportunity to come back to Clemson — are the unit's top returners.

SPECIALISTS Clemson returns starting placekicker Nolan Hauser and starting punter Jack Smith. Last year's top kickoff returner and punt returner both graduated, though, so expect competition at both spots.

FINAL ANALYSIS Last year was supposed to be epic for head coach Dabo Swinney's program. Instead, a team that returned almost everyone from its 2024 ACC championship and College Football Playoff team fell flat on its face, started 3-5 and limped to 7-6, Swinney's worst record since 2010.

Clemson's longtime coach responded by making multiple staff changes and using the portal more than ever. But Swinney's decision to stick with Vizzina and not pursue a transfer QB is a significant gamble ahead of what feels like a "prove-it" year for a program at a crossroads.

Clemson is just 26-14 overall (.650) and 15-9 in the ACC (.640) since 2023. That's a noticeable drop-off for a school that lost seven games *total* from 2015-20. Big games against LSU, Miami (Fla.) and South Carolina will be gut-checks.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 4-4 ACC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	LSU	L	10-17	Sept. 5	at LSU	1. Naeem Burroughs, WR	★★★★
Sept. 6	Troy	W	27-16	Sept. 12	Georgia Southern	2. Polo Anderson, S	★★★★
Sept. 13	at Georgia Tech	L	21-24	Sept. 19	North Carolina	3. Gordon Sellars III, WR	★★★★
Sept. 20	Syracuse	L	21-34	Sept. 25	at Cal	4. Brayden Reilly, LB	★★★★
Oct. 4	at North Carolina	W	38-10	Oct. 3	Miami (Fla.)	5. Chance Barclay, IOL	★★★★
Oct. 11	at Boston College	W	41-10	Oct. 17	Charleston Southern	6. Connor Salmin, WR	★★★★
Oct. 18	SMU	L	24-35	Oct. 24	Virginia Tech	7. Grant Wise, IOL	★★★★
Nov. 1	Duke	L	45-46	Oct. 31	at Florida State	8. Leo Delaney, IOL	★★★
Nov. 8	Florida State	W	24-10	Nov. 7	at Syracuse	9. Carter Scruggs, IOL	★★★
Nov. 14	at Louisville	W	20-19	Nov. 14	Georgia Tech	10. Adam Guthrie, OT	★★★
Nov. 22	Furman	W	45-10	Nov. 21	at Duke		
Nov. 29	at South Carolina	W	28-14	Nov. 28	South Carolina		
Dec. 27	vs. Penn State #	L	10-22				
#Pinstripe Bowl				TEAM INFORMATION			
				Head Coach: Dabo Swinney • Record at School: 187-53 (17+ years)			
				Career Record: 187-53 (17+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Chad Morris			
				Defensive Coordinator: Tom Allen • Location: Clemson, S.C.			
				Stadium: Memorial Stadium (81,500)			



T.J. MOORE

SCOUTING THE TIGERS

"It's almost like they overcoach their defensive players instead of letting them cut it loose and play. There were some schematic things where you felt like you could get them out of position. Usually, teams that are really talented do a little less and try to just let those guys cut it loose. ... Their backup QBs didn't play much last year, and I didn't think they were very good. I'd be shocked if they were better on offense even if they're coached better. When Clemson is good, their quarterback is really good. ... The same concepts that they ran in 2025, you can go back to the beginning when Dabo [Swinney] got there and see the same thing. I don't think it was [offensive coordinator] Garrett Riley's offense. It was essentially Chad Morris' offense being called by Garrett Riley."

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (5)

WR	12	BRYANT WESCO JR. (JR.)	22	Cole Turner (Jr.)
WR	1	T.J. MOORE (JR.)	19	Gordon Sellars III (Fr.)
WR	6	Tyler Brown (Jr.)	0	Naeem Burroughs (Fr.)
LT	74	Brayden Jacobs (So.)	54	Ian Reed (So.)
LG	52	Elyjah Thurmon (So.)	77	Ronan O'Connell (So.)
C	55	HARRIS SEWELL (SR.)	64	Grant Wise (Fr.)
RG	50	COLLIN SADLER (SR.)	75	Tucker Kattus (Fr.)
RT	63	Easton Ware (Fr.)	76	Mason Wade (So.)
TE	11	OLSEN PATT-HENRY (SR.)	87	Christian Bentancur (So.)
QB	17	Christopher Vizzina (Jr.)	2	Tait Reynolds (Fr.)
RB	8	Gideon Davidson (So.)	16	Chris Johnson Jr.* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	13	WILL HELDT (SR.)	17	Ari Watford (Fr.)
DT	99	Markus Strong* (Jr.)		Andy Burburija* (Jr.)
DT	45	Vic Burley (Jr.)	29	Champ Thompson (So.)
DE	15	Jahiem Lawson (Sr.)	14	London Merritt* (So.)
MLB	47	SAMMY BROWN (JR.)	7	Jeremiah Alexander (Sr.)
WLB	21	Kobe McCloud (Jr.)	50	Fletcher Cothran (Sr.)
CB	2	ASHTON HAMPTON (JR.)	0	Donovan Starr* (So.)
CB	3	Elliot Washington II* (Sr.)	1	Branden Strozier (Jr.)
NB	8	Corian Gipson (So.)	10	Misun Kelley (Jr.)
S	22	Corey Myrick* (Jr.)	5	Ronan Hanafin (Sr.)
S	6	Jerome Carter III* (Jr.)	11	Polo Anderson (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	81	Nolan Hauser (Jr.)	KR	8	Gideon Davidson (So.)
P	89	Jack Smith (Sr.)	PR	6	Tyler Brown (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



NATE SHEPPARD

SCOUTING THE BLUE DEVILS

"What's so tough in this era is the timing of when Duke lost [quarterback Darian Mensah] to Miami. There's no way that they thought they were going to lose him. So they didn't replace him or get someone comparable because why would someone comparable come while he's there? That's a tough blow. ... But the culture, the belief and the mindset are there at that place right now. One of the best things that Manny Diaz did when he became head coach was making sure he retained Dave Feeley, the head strength coach, and not lose him to Texas A&M. From a toughness, physicality and stability standpoint for them, that culture starts in the weight room."

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	Jared Richardson* (Sr.)	19	Kavon Simmons (Fr.)
WR	8 Jayden Moore (So.)	6	Jamien Little (Fr.)
WR	5 Javen Nicholas* (Sr.)	4	Jaivon Solomon (Fr.)
LT	56 Nick Del Grande* (Sr.)	66	Caleb Dorris (Jr.)
LG	64 JORDAN LARSEN (SR.)	74	Reagan McCranie (Jr.)
C	72 MATT CRAYCRAFT (SR.)	55	Ryan Daly (So.)
RG	63 Bradley Smith (So.)	76	Gemyel Allen (So.)
RT	75 Micah Sahakian (Sr.)	77	Braden Miller* (Sr.)
TE	85 JEREMIAH HASLEY (SR.)	15	Jake Taylor (Sr.)
QB	2 Walker Eget* (Sr.)	10	Dan Mahan (Fr.)
RB	20 NATE SHEPPARD (SO.)	0	CJ Campbell Jr.* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (3)

VYPER	10 Tyshon Reed (Jr.)	43	Semaj Turner (So.)
NT	44 David Anderson (Jr.)	55	Julius Columbus (Fr.)
DT	95 Preston Watson (Jr.)	99	Dakota Quiñonez* (Sr.)
DE	14 Bryce Davis (So.)	15	Kevin O'Connor (Jr.)
MLB	34 LUKE MERGOTT (JR.)	36	Nick Morris Jr. (Sr.)
WLB	42 Kendall Johnson (Jr.)	24	Bradley Gompers (So.)
STAR	30 Will Felder Jr. (Fr.)	31	Elliott Schaper (So.)
CB	21 Landon Callahan (So.)	28	Kaleb Lanier (Fr.)
CB	5 KIMARI ROBINSON (JR.)	0	Dylan Flowers* (Sr.)
ROVER	8 DASHAWN STONE (JR.)	6	Leon Griffin III (Jr.)
FS	Patrick Smith-Young* (Sr.)		Ché Ojarikre* (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	39 Cosme Salas (So.)	KR	8 Jayden Moore (So.)
P	41 Kade Reynoldson (Jr.)	PR	20 Nate Sheppard (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



DUKE BLUE DEVILS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 54 | ACC PREDICTION: 13 | 2025 RECORD: 9-5, 6-2 ACC

OFFENSE The ACC's top scoring offense (34.6 ppg) propelled Duke to its first ACC championship since 1989. A quarterback change necessitated by Darian Mensah's controversial last-minute portal move to Miami (Fla.) and Walker Eget's arrival from San José State could make that level of production more difficult to attain. Eget completed 59% of his passes last season, throwing for 3,051 yards with 17 touchdowns and nine interceptions. Those numbers don't quite match Mensah's. But given the circumstances, the Blue Devils are in decent shape there.

Duke retained running back Nate Sheppard, who turned in a fabulous freshman season with 1,132 rushing yards and 11 touchdowns. He'll run behind an offensive line that returns two starters — left guard Jordan Larsen and center Matt Craycraft. Right tackle Micah Sahakian is back after missing last season with an injury. Coastal Carolina transfer Nick Del Grande, a two-time All-Sun Belt pick, slots in at left tackle.

Duke will count on FCS Penn transfer Jared Richardson, a 1,000-yard receiver last season, to start.

DEFENSE Though head coach Manny Diaz is known for his defensive prowess, the Blue Devils won the ACC despite finishing in the bottom half of the league in scoring defense (29.4 ppg, 14th) and total defense (424.2 ypg, 15th). Duke needs a host of reserves to step into starting roles.

Up front, David Anderson, Preston Watson and Tyshod Reed will get opportunities. Senior linebacker Nick Morris Jr. is returning from a torn ACL, and Duke needs more contributions from Luke Mergott, who stepped in and made big plays last season.

The secondary needs transfers Dylan Flowers (WKU), Evan Smith (Northwestern) and Patrick Smith-Young (North Texas) to jell quickly with returners Landon Callahan and DaShawn Stone.

SPECIALISTS Cosme Salas, Duke's kickoff specialist as a freshman last season, steps into full placekicking duties as a sophomore. His leg is strong, but he needs to prove he's accurate as well. Duke has one of the ACC's better punters in Kade Reynoldson, who averaged 44.6 yards per attempt as a sophomore. Sheppard could bring explosiveness as a punt returner, and the same goes for wide receiver Jayden Moore on kickoffs.

FINAL ANALYSIS Duke reached an impressive milestone with its ACC championship. Still, the Blue Devils lost five regular-season games, making the title game as a result of a series of tiebreakers. It looks unlikely that the offense will match last season's production, which means the defense needs to improve. So many new faces could make that difficult.

2025 RESULTS (9-5, 6-2 ACC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*					
Aug. 28	Elon	W	45-17	Sept. 5	Tulane	1. Obinna Umeh, EDGE	★★★★				
Sept. 6	Illinois	L	19-45	Sept. 12	at Illinois	2. CJ Givers, RB	★★★				
Sept. 13	at Tulane	L	27-34	Sept. 19	Stanford	3. Terry Walker III, QB	★★★				
Sept. 20	NC State	W	45-33	Sept. 26	William & Mary	4. Lyrik Pettis, S	★★★				
Sept. 27	at Syracuse	W	38-3	Oct. 10	at Georgia Tech	5. Benjamin Moseley, TE	★★★				
Oct. 4	at Cal	W	45-21	Oct. 17	North Carolina	6. Sean Stover, IOL	★★★				
Oct. 18	Georgia Tech	L	18-27	Oct. 24	at Virginia	7. Chadwicke Cannon Jr., DL	★★★				
Nov. 1	at Clemson	W	46-45	Oct. 31	Boston College	8. Brody Keefe, WR	★★★				
Nov. 8	at UConn	L	34-37	Nov. 7	at NC State	9. Tyson Sanford, CB	★★★				
Nov. 15	Virginia	L	17-34	Nov. 14	at Miami (Fla.)	10. Jayvian Tanelus, RB	★★★				
Nov. 22	at North Carolina	W	32-25	Nov. 21	Clemson						
Nov. 29	Wake Forest	W	49-32	Nov. 28	at Wake Forest						
Dec. 6	vs. Virginia # (ot)	W	27-20								
Dec. 31	vs. Arizona State %	W	42-39								
#Charlotte, NC Sun Bowl				*Per Rivals							
TEAM INFORMATION											
Head Coach: Manny Diaz • Record at School: 18-9 (2 years)											
Career Record: 39-24 (5 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Jonathan Brewer											
Defensive Coordinator: Jonathan Patke • Location: Durham, N.C.											
Stadium: Wallace Wade Stadium (35,018)											



FLORIDA STATE SEMINOLES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 48 | ACC PREDICTION: 11 | 2025 RECORD: 5-7, 2-6 ACC

OFFENSE Florida State is breaking in a new starting quarterback for the third consecutive season and is tasked with replacing its entire offensive line for the second straight year. Transfer quarterback Ashton Daniels has been inconsistent throughout his college career, but he had some promising flashes in limited action at Auburn in 2025.

The Seminoles do bring some promising playmakers to the table. Duce Robinson and Micahi Danzy could blossom into one of the best wide receiver duos in the country. Robinson is coming off a 1,000-yard season, while Danzy's explosiveness leaves opposing defenses in the dust.

FSU has a three-headed monster at running back with Texas transfer Quintrevion Wisner joining Ousmane Kromah and Samuel Singleton Jr. It's a group that will give opposing defenses fits.

DEFENSE The Seminoles revamped their defense over the offseason, bringing in multiple transfers to fortify the unit. The added talent in the middle will help shore up a weakness from a year ago. Southern Miss transfer Chris Jones was among the top-10 tacklers in the FBS in 2025, and North Carolina transfer Mikai Gbayor has previous experience playing under defensive coordinator Tony White when both were at Nebraska.

Florida State has questions in the trenches, although the team did retain twin defensive linemen Darryll and Desir Mandrell. Daniel Lyons has grown into a leader in the middle. Rylan Kennedy (Texas A&M) was the only defensive end the Seminoles added through the transfer portal.

On the back end, cornerback Ja'Bril Rawls and rover Ashlynd Barker are two crucial pieces to the success of the unit.

SPECIALISTS This unit is relatively unknown, as former Oklahoma State kicker Gabe Panikowski and former New Mexico punter Daniel Hughes transferred to Tallahassee, along with North Dakota State long-snapper Caleb Bowers. The options in the return game are intriguing, with dynamic threats such as Singleton, Danzy, Jasen Lopez and Devin Carter.

FINAL ANALYSIS Head coach Mike Norvell enters his seventh season at Florida State firmly on the hot seat. The Seminoles have missed the post-season four times in the past six years and are just 7-18 overall since being infamously snubbed from the College Football Playoff after the 2023 regular season. The schedule does Norvell no favors. FSU faces Alabama in Tuscaloosa after hosting SMU on Labor Day. There is also a pair of two-game road trips to grapple with, and it's been more than two years since the program won outside of Doak Campbell Stadium.

In the end, Florida State's lack of urgency to invest in a top quarterback transfer will likely come back to bite Norvell, who might be gearing up for his final chance to right the ship.

2025 RESULTS (5-7, 2-6 ACC)			2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Alabama	W 31-17	Aug. 29	New Mexico State	1. Izayia Williams, LB	★★★★
Sept. 6	East Texas A&M	W 77-3	Sept. 7	SMU	2. Earnest Rankins, DL	★★★★
Sept. 20	Kent State	W 66-10	Sept. 19	at Alabama	3. Chuck Kennon, CB	★★★★
Sept. 26	at Virginia (ot)	L 38-46	Sept. 26	Central Arkansas	4. Jaemin Pinckney, EDGE	★★★★
Oct. 4	Miami (Fla.)	L 22-28	Oct. 3	Virginia	5. Amari Thomas, RB	★★★★
Oct. 11	Pitt	L 31-34	Oct. 9	at Louisville	6. Jasen Lopez, WR	★★★★
Oct. 18	at Stanford	L 13-20	Oct. 17	at Miami (Fla.)	7. Tre Bell III, S	★★★★
Nov. 1	Wake Forest	W 42-7	Oct. 31	Clemson	8. EJ White, ATH	★★★★
Nov. 8	at Clemson	L 10-24	Nov. 7	at Boston College	9. Jordan Crutchfield, S	★★★
Nov. 15	Virginia Tech	W 34-14	Nov. 13	at Pitt	10. Karon Maycock, LB	★★★
Nov. 21	at NC State	L 11-21	Nov. 21	NC State		
Nov. 29	at Florida	L 21-40	Nov. 27	Florida		

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Mike Norvell • Record at School: 38-34 (6 years) • Career Record: 76-49 (10 years) • Offensive Coordinators: Mike Norvell, Tim Harris Jr. • Defensive Coordinator: Tony White • Location: Tallahassee, Fla. • Stadium: Doak Campbell Stadium (67,277)



DUCE ROBINSON

SCOUTING THE SEMINOLES

"They don't have the booster support that people might think that they do. The volatility with [head coach] Mike Norvell is something that I've never seen. Norvell is a really good coach, but one of the hardest things in football is fighting complacency. I think once things started going well, they gave in an inch here and there, then you look back in a year and you see that you gave up a mile. ... They can reinvent themselves and be who they set out to be. But can they do it consistently and not just a flash in the pan? With a new group of people and some new coaches, I think it can be reversed. The players have to take charge of that."

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	0	DUCE ROBINSON (SR.)	13	Tae'Shaun Gelsey (Fr.)
WR	8	MICAH DANZY (SO.)	11	Devin Carter (Fr.)
WR	15	Jayvan Boggs (So.)	7	Jasen Lopez (Fr.)
LT	77	Xavier Chaplin* (Sr.)	74	Jonathan Daniels (So.)
LG	65	André Otto (Jr.)	78	Jayden Todd (So.)
C	55	Bradyn Joiner* (Jr.)	52	Chavez Thompson (Fr.)
RG	71	Nate Pabst* (Sr.)	51	Paul Bowling* (So.)
RT	79	Chimdia Nwaiwu* (Jr.)	71	Nate Pabst* (Sr.)
TE	6	Desirio Riles* (Sr.)	18	Landen Thomas (Jr.)
QB	14	Ashton Daniels* (Sr.)	9	Kevin Sperry (Fr.)
RB	5	Quintrevion Wisner* (Sr.)	32	Ousmane Kromah (So.)

DEFENSE (4)

JACK	15	Rylan Kennedy* (Sr.)	32	Jalen Anderson (Jr.)
NT	5	DANIEL LYONS (SR.)	55	Kevin Wynn (Fr.)
DT	8	Deante McCray (Sr.)	3	Mandrell Desir (So.)
DE	1	Darryll Desir (So.)	13	Deamontae Diggs (Sr.)
MLB	10	Chris Jones* (Jr.)	28	Mikai Gbayor* (Sr.)
LB	20	BLAKE NICHOLSON (SR.)	9	Omar Graham Jr. (Sr.)
CB	6	JA'BRIL RAWLS (JR.)	12	Nehemiah Chandler* (So.)
CB	0	Quindarius Jones (Sr.)	4	Charles Lester III (So.)
ROVER	7	ASHLYND BARKER (SR.)	37	Tre Bell III (Fr.)
S	11	CJ Richard Jr.* (So.)	24	K.J. Kirkland (Jr.)
S	14	Ma'Khi Jones* (So.)	16	Karson Hobbs* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	39	Gabe Panikowski* (Sr.)	KR	3	Samuel Singleton Jr. (Jr.)
P	36	Daniel Hughes* (Jr.)	PR	7	Jasen Lopez (Fr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



MALACHI HOSLEY

SCOUTING THE YELLOW JACKETS

"I'm most interested in how it's going to look without [quarterback] Haynes King and [offensive coordinator] Buster Faulkner. Those two hid a lot of deficiencies within that program. Single-handedly as a player and single-handedly as a play-caller, they affected games more than talent or culture. I don't know that they would've been more than average without those two people. Now they're on their fourth defensive coordinator in four years. I would imagine that's a cause for concern. ... [Michigan transfer running back] Justice Haynes is a f—ing savage. I saw him hit a guy and it was like two cars hitting each other. Great balance, great vision. Such a physical back. I think he's going to be a big-time NFL back."

—An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	4	Jordan Allen (So.)	14	Dalen Penson (So.)
WR	13	Isaiah Fuhrmann* (Jr.)	16	Jaiven Plummer* (Sr.)
LT	78	ETHAN MACKENNY (JR.)	79	Jordan Floyd (So.)
LG	52	Kevin Peay Jr. (Fr.)	65	Courtney Heard (Fr.)
C	69	Joseph Itona* (So.)	66	Will Reed (Sr.)
RG	72	MALACHI CARNEY (SR.)	62	Courtlin Heard (Fr.)
RT	70	Jameson Riggs (So.)	71	Markell Samuel* (Sr.)
TE	17	Chris Corbo* (Sr.)	44	Spencer Mermans* (Jr.)
TE/HB	8	Gavin Harris* (Sr.)	86	Kevin Roche Jr. (Fr.)
QB	15	Alberto Mendoza* (So.)	9	Grady Adamson (Fr.)
RB	22	Justice Haynes* (Sr.)	0	Malachi Hosley (Sr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	10	Jordan Walker* (Sr.)	88	A.J. HOFFLER (SR.)
NT	99	Vincent Carroll-Jackson* (Jr.)	92	Christian Speakman (Fr.)
DT	95	Tawfiq Thomas* (Sr.)	55	Christian Garrett (Fr.)
DE	9	AMONTRAE BRADFORD (JR.)	91	Andre Fuller Jr. (So.)
LB	44	KYLE EFFORD (SR.)	1	Cayman Spaulding (Sr.)
LB	2	E.J. LIGHTSEY (SR.)	45	Melvin Jordan IV (Sr.)
CB	3	Jaylen Mbakwe* (Jr.)	4	Daiquan White (Sr.)
CB	29	Jonas Duclona* (Jr.)	5	ZACHARY TOBE (SR.)
NB	16	Kelvin Hill (Jr.)	28	Elgin Sessions (So.)
S	27	Tae Harris (So.)	32	Jayden Barr (Fr.)
S	13	Savion Riley (Sr.)	31	Fenix Felton (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	33	Aidan Birr (Sr.)	KR	24	Shane Marshall (So.)
P		Alex Bacchetta* (Sr.)	PR	3	Jaylen Mbakwe* (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



GEORGIA TECH YELLOW JACKETS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 41 | ACC PREDICTION: 8 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 6-2 ACC

OFFENSE Georgia Tech will have a new offensive coordinator, former Jackets quarterback and veteran NFL assistant George Godsey, and a new quarterback, with Haynes King graduating after three years as the starter. The Jackets will likely return to a more run-heavy, ball-control type of system, as head coach Brent Key wants a tough, physical brand of football.

Filling King's shoes will be a tough assignment, but transfer Alberto Mendoza is expected to get the first shot following a year spent backing up his brother, 2025 Heisman Trophy winner Fernando, at Indiana.

Tech made its biggest portal splash at running back with the acquisition of Justice Haynes, who has shown dynamic playmaking ability during stints at Alabama and Michigan. He will pair with Malachi Hosley, who led Jackets RBs last year with 697 rushing yards.

Attrition hit the wide receiver and tight end positions hard. Speedy Jordan Allen returns with higher expectations after a solid true freshman campaign at WR, and FCS Elon transfer Isaiah Fuhrmann is a bigger-bodied target. At tight end, several transfers will fill key roles in an offense that uses the position in a variety of ways.

The offensive line will have three new starters along with returnees Ethan Mackenny at left tackle and Malachi Carney, who is expected to move to guard after starting at right tackle in 2025.

DEFENSE New defensive coordinator Jason Semore will emphasize aggressiveness and takeaways after the unit struggled to force turnovers (nine) and get to the quarterback (13 sacks) in 2025.

The line lost several key contributors, but the coaching staff made it a priority to build depth and emphasize size in the portal. Linebackers Kyle Efford and E.J. Lightsey return as the two top tacklers from 2025, but in a new system, the pair will likely have to earn their spots again.

Question marks fill the back end following the loss to graduation of two starters at corner and two starters at safety. Transfers Jaylen Mbakwe and Jonas Duclona should step in at corner, while returning safeties Tae Harris and Fenix Felton look to take their games to a new level.

SPECIALISTS The Jackets return one of the best placekickers in the country in Aidan Birr, who had multiple clutch field goals in 2025. The punting situation will be a battle between an incoming transfer, a freshman and a walk-on. There are multiple talented playmakers in the return game.

FINAL ANALYSIS The roster is much younger, the Jackets have new coordinators and multiple new assistants and the schedule appears to be tougher. Key and his staff have done a good job filling holes in the roster, but how it all comes together is the million-dollar question.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 6-2 ACC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*					
Aug. 29	at Colorado	W	27-20	Sept. 3	Colorado	1. Trae Stevenson Jr., CB	★★★★				
Sept. 6	Gardner-Webb	W	59-12	Sept. 12	Tennessee	2. Cole Bergeron, QB	★★★★				
Sept. 13	Clemson	W	24-21	Sept. 19	Mercer	3. Darnell Collins, ATH	★★★★				
Sept. 20	Temple	W	45-24	Sept. 26	at Stanford	4. Amier Clarke, DL	★★★★				
Sept. 27	at Wake Forest (ot)	W	30-29	Oct. 10	Duke	5. Jaedyn Terry, CB	★★★				
Oct. 11	Virginia Tech	W	35-20	Oct. 17	at Virginia Tech	6. Kealan Jones, S	★★★				
Oct. 18	at Duke	W	27-18	Oct. 24	Boston College	7. Courtney Heard, OT	★★★				
Oct. 25	Syracuse	W	41-16	Oct. 31	at Pitt	8. Braylon Outlaw, LB	★★★				
Nov. 1	at NC State	L	36-48	Nov. 7	Louisville	9. Kentrell Davis, WR	★★★				
Nov. 15	at Boston College	W	36-34	Nov. 14	at Clemson	10. Jack Richerson, TE	★★★				
Nov. 22	Pitt	L	28-42	Nov. 21	Wake Forest						
Nov. 28	Georgia	L	9-16	Nov. 28	at Georgia						
Dec. 27	vs. BYU #	L	21-25								
#Pop-Tarts Bowl				*Per Rivals							
TEAM INFORMATION											
Head Coach: Brent Key • Record at School: 27-20 (3+ years)											
Career Record: 27-20 (3+ years) • Offensive Coordinators: George Godsey, Chris Weinke • Defensive Coordinator: Jason Semore • Location: Atlanta, Ga.											
Stadium: Bobby Dodd Stadium (51,913)											



LOUISVILLE CARDINALS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 23 | ACC PREDICTION: 3 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 4-4 ACC

OFFENSE Head coach Jeff Brohm has brought several transfer quarterbacks to Louisville, but none quite like Lincoln Kienholz. Kienholz made only seven appearances in three seasons at Ohio State, despite pushing Julian Sayin for the starting job in 2025. He also provides mobility to complement All-ACC running back Isaac Brown. “Lincoln gives us a dimension we have not had,” Brohm says. “He’s a really good athlete. He’s got a good arm. He just doesn’t have the game experience, but he has a ton of talent.”

Louisville added FCS West Georgia transfer Davin Wydner to compete with Kienholz. The team retained Brown after a portal scare, but the Cardinals will be rebuilding at wide receiver after losing their top three targets. Louisville added potential impact transfers in Tre Richardson (Vanderbilt) and Lawayne McCoy (Florida State), as well as tight end Brody Foley (Tulsa). “I would like to be more explosive in the passing game,” Brohm says.

The line is also transfer-heavy, with guard Eryx Daugherty (Boston College) and center Evan Wibberley (Kentucky) among the additions.

DEFENSE Louisville invested greatly along its defensive line and has depth on the edges with All-ACC selection Clev Lubin, North Carolina transfer Tyler Thompson and others. A key will be bolstering the interior with transfers like Purdue’s Demeco Kennedy.

Linebackers T.J. Capers and Antonio Watts combined for 88 tackles (9.5 for a loss). Stanquan Clark, the team’s second-leading tackler in 2024, is back following an injury-shortened 2025 season.

The Cardinals went transfer hunting in the secondary, plucking a rare established Iowa defender in safety Koen Entringer, a captain with 73 tackles for the Hawkeyes last season. “He’s really good, he’s smart, he’s experienced,” Brohm says of Entringer. Cornerback Tayon Holloway returns after recording two interceptions and five pass breakups.

SPECIALISTS There’s competition at placekicker between local standout Carson Hilbert and veteran Nick Keller, while FCS Eastern Kentucky transfer Jacob Baker arrives at punter. Transfer receivers Richardson and Jackson Voth are among those with experience on returns.

FINAL ANALYSIS Brohm will try to fast-track Kienholz and a new-look group of receivers while leaning on Brown and emphasizing line-of-scrimmage play. Louisville has a challenging opener against Ole Miss in Nashville but doesn’t play Miami (Fla.) or Virginia. “We’ve gained some quality personnel, we’ve got the right mix of youth and experience,” Brohm says. “Now it’s just a matter of piecing it together.”

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 4-4 ACC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Eastern Kentucky	W	51-17	Sept. 6	vs. Ole Miss #	1. Jaydin Broadnax, CB	★★★★
Sept. 5	James Madison	W	28-14	Sept. 11	Villanova	2. Julius Miles, TE	★★★★
Sept. 20	Bowling Green	W	40-17	Sept. 19	SMU	3. Briggs Cherry, QB	★★★★
Sept. 27	at Pitt	W	34-27	Sept. 26	Wake Forest	4. Jarvis Strickland, OT	★★★
Oct. 4	Virginia (ot)	L	27-30	Oct. 3	at NC State	5. Jordan Vann, S	★★★
Oct. 17	at Miami (Fla.)	W	24-21	Oct. 9	Florida State	6. Payton Cook, WR	★★★
Oct. 25	Boston College	W	38-24	Oct. 17	at Syracuse	7. Lekhy Thompkins, RB	★★★
Nov. 1	at Virginia Tech	W	28-16	Oct. 31	Stanford	8. Taj Powell, LB	★★★
Nov. 8	Cal (ot)	L	26-29	Nov. 7	at Georgia Tech	9. Gavin Waddell, WR	★★★
Nov. 14	Clemson	L	19-20	Nov. 14	at North Carolina	10. Charlie Edgeworth, OT	★★★
Nov. 22	at SMU	L	6-38	Nov. 21	Pitt		
Nov. 29	Kentucky	W	41-0	Nov. 28	at Kentucky		
Dec. 23	vs. Toledo #	W	27-22		#Nashville, TN		*Per Rivals
			#Boca Raton Bowl				
TEAM INFORMATION							
Head Coach: Jeff Brohm • Record at School: 28-12 (3 years)							
Career Record: 94-56 (12 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Brian Brohm							
Defensive Coordinators: Steve Ellis, Mark Ivey • Location: Louisville, Ky.							
Stadium: L&N Federal Credit Union Stadium (60,800)							



ISAAC BROWN

SCOUTING THE CARDINALS

“They got a good portal quarterback. [Ohio State transfer quarterback Lincoln Kienholz] is gonna be better than what people anticipate. They’ll be decent, but overall, there’s a little less excitement in the program than there was two years ago. ... I think the [Louisville general manager] Vince Marrow deal is weird, and my guess is that it won’t go well in the long run. Just from player evaluation and getting the right players, I don’t know that he and [Louisville head coach Jeff Brohm] totally see eye to eye with that. Long term, is that the guy to hitch your wagon to? I don’t know. Losing their offensive line coach [Richard Owens], who was really good and ended up at Alabama, that’s a big loss for them.”

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	2	TREYSHUN HURRY (SR.)	82	Terrence McWilliams Jr. (Jr.)
WR	0	Tre Richardson* (Sr.)	86	Jackson Voth* (Jr.)
WR	7	Lawayne McCoy (Jr.)	14	Kris Hughes (Jr.)
LT	70	Anwar O’neal* (Sr.)	66	Johnnie Brown III* (Fr.)
LG	56	Eryx Daugherty* (Jr.)	55	Jimmy Williams III (So.)
C	58	Evan Wibberley* (Sr.)	72	Sam Secrest (Sr.)
RG	53	LANCE ROBINSON (SR.)	57	Naeer Jackson (Sr.)
RT	71	Cason Henry* (Sr.)	75	Cameron Gorin (Fr.)
TE	80	Brody Foley* (Sr.)	18	Jaleel Skinner (Sr.)
QB	3	Lincoln Kienholz* (Jr.)	11	Davin Wydner* (Jr.)
RB	1	ISAAC BROWN (JR.)	5	Keyjuan Brown (Jr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	17	AJ Green (Jr.)	3	Tyler Thompson* (Jr.)
DT	2	Demeco Kennedy* (Jr.)	90	Daylen Russell* (Fr.)
DT	95	Joshua Donald* (Jr.)	96	Tommy Ziesmer (Jr.)
DE	50	CLEV LUBIN (SR.)	99	Jerod Smith II* (Jr.)
LB	11	T.J. CAPERS (JR.)	23	Benjamin Perry* (Sr.)
LB	6	STANQUAN CLARK (SR.)	38	Cameron White (Fr.)
LB	9	ANTONIO WATTS (SR.)	43	Trent Carter (So.)
CB	13	TAYON HOLLOWAY (SR.)	25	Brycen Scott* (Jr.)
CB	12	DJ Waller Jr.* (Jr.)	28	Santana Wilson* (So.)
S	5	Koen Entringer* (Jr.)	26	Jordan Vann (Fr.)
S	10	Kaleb Beasley* (Jr.)	4	T.J. Banks* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	35	Carson Hilbert (Fr.)	KR	0	Tre Richardson* (Sr.)
P	48	Jacob Baker* (Jr.)	PR	86	Jackson Voth* (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



MALACHI TONEY

SCOUTING THE HURRICANES

"They're absolutely the favorite in the ACC. [Head coach] Mario Cristobal has enough scars from losing heartbreaking games the last couple of years that he is not going to let that happen again. The people there that he's finally surrounded himself with are going to be in position to give him guidance, especially on game day, management of the game, all of those kinds of things with just making decisions to win the game. He's phenomenal around recruits. When it comes to getting big-time players to come there, he's special. It's great to see his growth as a head coach. I truly think that the painful losses that he's had the last couple years will be the reason why he makes sure that he wins the ACC this year."

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	18	Cooper Barkate* (Sr.)	8	Vandrevius Jacobs* (Jr.)
WR	17	Cam Vaughn* (Jr.)	3	Joshua Moore (So.)
WR	10	MALACHI TONEY (SO.)	13	Vance Spafford (Fr.)
LT	78	MATTHEW MCCOY (SR.)	72	Demetrius Campbell (Fr.)
LG	71	Jamal Meriweather* (Jr.)	66	Max Buchanan (So.)
C	76	Ryan Rodriguez (Sr.)	65	Seuseu Alofaituli (So.)
RG	63	Samson Okunlola (Jr.)	77	Juan Minaya (So.)
RT	79	Jackson Cantwell (Fr.)	71	Jaden Wilkerson (Fr.)
TE	9	Elija Lofton (Jr.)	88	Luka Gilbert (So.)
QB	10	Darian Mensah* (Jr.)	16	Luke Nickel (Fr.)
RB	4	MARK FLETCHER JR. (SR.)	6	CharMar Brown (Jr.)

DEFENSE (6)

DE	10	Damon Wilson II* (Sr.)	18	Armondo Blount (Jr.)
DT	99	AHMAD MOTEN SR. (SR.)	91	Jarquez Carter* (So.)
DT	5	JUSTIN SCOTT (JR.)	97	Keona Davis* (Jr.)
DE	12	Marquise Lightfoot (Jr.)	14	Hayden Lowe (Fr.)
OLB	32	Kamal Bonner (Jr.)	22	Cam Pruitt (Jr.)
ILB	1	MOHAMED TOURE (SR.)	41	Chase Smith (Sr.)
CB	29	ROMANAS FREDERIQUE JR. (JR.)	2	Damari Brown (Jr.)
CB	6	XAVIER LUCAS (JR.)	24	Ethan O'Connor (Jr.)
NB	0	Omar Thornton* (Jr.)	13	Bryce Fitzgerald (So.)
S	7	ZECHARIAH POYSER (JR.)	23	Dylan Day (Jr.)
S	13	Bryce Fitzgerald (So.)	38	Conrad Hussey* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	82	Jack Olsen* (Sr.)	KR	2	Jordan Lyle (Jr.)
P	94	Dylan Joyce (Sr.)	PR	10	Malachi Toney (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN **BOLD** • *2026 TRANSFER



MIAMI HURRICANES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 7 | ACC PREDICTION: 1 | 2025 RECORD: 13-3, 6-2 ACC

OFFENSE Miami has explosive pieces on offense, led by former Duke standout quarterback Darian Mensah, who threw for 34 touchdowns and only six interceptions in leading the Blue Devils to the ACC title in 2025. The Hurricanes also picked up his favorite target at Duke — Cooper Barkate (1,106 yards, seven TDs last season). Now add in the return of one of the nation's most explosive slot threats in Malachi Toney (1,211 yards, 10 TDs), as well as running back Mark Fletcher Jr. (1,192 yards, 12 TDs), and the Canes have no shortage of weapons.

The big question is an offensive line that loses four starters and is relying on oft-injured center Ryan Rodriguez, true freshman tackle Jackson Cantwell and former 5-star recruit Samson Okunlola. The lone returner up front is Matthew McCoy, who could play guard or tackle.

DEFENSE Despite some key losses — including star ends Rueben Bain Jr. and Akheem Mesidor — this should once again be a playmaking group. Miami added fearsome Missouri pass rusher Damon Wilson II (nine sacks in 2025), and the team returns Marquise Lightfoot (2.5 sacks), DE/DT Armondo Blount (2.5 sacks), starting tackles Ahmad Moten Sr. (4.5 sacks) and Justin Scott (6.5 tackles for a loss).

The top four cornerbacks return, led by Romanas "OJ" Frederique Jr. (seven pass breakups) and Xavier Lucas (45 tackles, INT). Starting safety Zechariah Poyser (68 tackles) is joined by nickel/S Bryce Fitzgerald (six INTs) and Boston College transfer Omar Thornton (82 tackles).

An area of concern depth-wise is at linebacker. Mohamed Toure (84 tackles) is back, but the position has question marks, as guys like Chase Smith and former NC State transfer Kamal Bonner need to step up.

SPECIALISTS Northwestern transfer Jack Olsen (19-of-21 on field goals, with a long of 41 yards) will handle field goals with Florida State transfer Jake Weinberg handling kickoffs. Punter Dylan Joyce is one of the ACC's best, averaging 44.4 yards per punt last season. The return game should be explosive behind the speedy Toney (13.0 yards per punt return).

FINAL ANALYSIS Fresh off a run to the national title game, this year's Hurricanes might even be better. The offense has a pair of 1,000-yard receivers (Barkate, Toney), a 1,000-yard rusher (Fletcher) and one of the ACC's top returning QBs (Mensah). The defense added a massive pass-rush threat in Wilson and returns six starters. Head coach Mario Cristobal's roster-building has positioned Miami as an ACC favorite and legitimate national title threat.

2025 RESULTS (13-3, 6-2 ACC)

Aug. 31	Notre Dame	W	27-24
Sept. 6	Bethune-Cookman	W	45-3
Sept. 13	South Florida	W	49-12
Sept. 20	Florida	W	26-7
Oct. 4	at Florida State	W	28-22
Oct. 17	Louisville	L	21-24
Oct. 25	Stanford	W	42-7
Nov. 1	at SMU (ot)	L	20-26
Nov. 8	Syracuse	W	38-10
Nov. 15	NC State	W	41-7
Nov. 22	at Virginia Tech	W	34-17
Nov. 29	at Pitt	W	38-7
Dec. 20	at Texas A&M #	W	10-3
Dec. 31	vs. Ohio State %	W	24-14
Jan. 8	vs. Ole Miss &	W	31-27
Jan. 19	vs. Indiana \$	L	21-27

#CFB Playoff First Round %Cotton Bowl: CFB Playoff Quarterfinal & Fiesta Bowl: CFB Playoff Semifinal \$Miami: CFB Playoff National Championship

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 4	at Stanford
Sept. 10	Florida A&M
Sept. 18	at Wake Forest
Sept. 26	Central Michigan
Oct. 3	at Clemson
Oct. 17	Florida State
Oct. 24	Pitt
Oct. 31	at North Carolina
Nov. 7	at Notre Dame
Nov. 14	Duke
Nov. 20	Virginia Tech
Nov. 28	Boston College

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1.	Jackson Cantwell, OT	★★★★★
2.	Somourian Wingo, WR	★★★★
3.	Gavin Mueller, TE	★★★★
4.	Asharri Charles, EDGE	★★★★
5.	Keshawn Stancil, DL	★★★★
6.	Milan Parris, WR	★★★★
7.	Ben Congdon, OT	★★★★
8.	Jaalen Waters, CB	★★★★
9.	Brody Jennings, CB	★★★★
10.	JJ Dunnigan, S	★★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Mario Cristobal • Record at School: 35-19 (4 years)
Career Record: 97-79 (14+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Shannon Dawson
Defensive Coordinator: Corey Hetherman • Location: Coral Gables, Fla.
Stadium: Hard Rock Stadium (64,767)



NORTH CAROLINA TAR HEELS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 56 | ACC PREDICTION: 14 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 2-6 ACC

OFFENSE The success of North Carolina's offense will likely hinge on the quarterback decision and how quickly a rebuilt offensive line stabilizes. If Wisconsin transfer Billy Edwards Jr. wins the QB job, expect a controlled version of new offensive coordinator Bobby Petrino's scheme — quick-game concepts and selective deep shots. Edwards brings experience (520 career attempts at the Power 4 level) but lacks elite arm strength and experience in systems that align with Petrino's preferences. If Texas A&M transfer Miles O'Neill is pushed into the role, the ceiling rises, but so does the risk behind an unproven offensive line replacing all five starters.

Center Christo Kelly is the key piece for UNC's O-line after returning from injury, bringing more than 20 career starts from his time at FCS Holy Cross and leadership to a unit otherwise short on Power 4 experience. The tackles — long, physically imposing options like Jordan Hall — fit the prototype but remain unproven in pass protection, a critical variable in a Petrino system that prefers leaving tackles on an island. Skill talent is intriguing but largely undefined; this offense may lean on efficiency over explosiveness early while searching for identity.

DEFENSE There is more clarity on this side of the ball. Coordinator Steve Belichick inherits a defensive front anchored by Melkart Abou Jaoude, who posted 47 tackles and finished second in the ACC with 10.5 sacks last season. His return provides both production and leadership for a unit that brings back multiple contributors along the line.

The broader question is consistency. UNC struggled with fundamentals in 2025 — tackling, alignment, communication — and Belichick's system prioritizes those details. The linebacker room is being rebuilt, and the secondary features a mix of veterans and transfers who must quickly jell in a matchup-driven scheme. If the front generates pressure, the defense can take a step forward; if not, the lack of depth at linebacker could be exposed.

SPECIALISTS The kicking game is relatively stable, led by transfer place-kicker Aeron Burrell and punter Jacob Horvath. Return production is less certain, with multiple options competing to replace departed contributors. Overall, this unit projects as steady but unspectacular.

FINAL ANALYSIS The offense has upside within Petrino's system, but early-season matchups against top defenses could mask progress while the offensive line and quarterback position settle. Defensively, improvement is more about execution, with Abou Jaoude providing a reliable anchor.

If the offensive line develops quickly and the quarterback situation stabilizes, UNC has the coaching to outperform last year's 4-8 mark. If not, inconsistency — particularly early — could again define the season.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 2-6 ACC)

Sept. 1	TCU	L	14-48
Sept. 6	at Charlotte	W	20-3
Sept. 13	Richmond	W	41-6
Sept. 20	at UCF	L	9-34
Oct. 4	Clemson	L	10-38
Oct. 17	at Cal	L	18-21
Oct. 25	Virginia (ot)	L	16-17
Oct. 31	at Syracuse	W	27-10
Nov. 8	Stanford	W	20-15
Nov. 15	at Wake Forest	L	12-28
Nov. 22	Duke	L	25-32
Nov. 29	at NC State	L	19-42

2026 SCHEDULE

Aug. 29	vs. TCU #
Sept. 12	East Tennessee St.
Sept. 19	at Clemson
Oct. 3	Notre Dame
Oct. 10	at Pitt
Oct. 17	at Duke
Oct. 24	Syracuse
Oct. 31	Miami (Fla.)
Nov. 7	at UConn
Nov. 14	Louisville
Nov. 21	at Virginia
Nov. 28	NC State

#Dublin, Ireland

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Kenton Dopson III, CB	★★★★
2. Jakob Weatherspoon, S	★★★★
3. Calvin Thomas, LB	★★★★
4. J.B. Shabazz, OT	★★★★
5. C.J. Sadler, ATH	★★★★
6. Keeyun Chapman, WR	★★★★
7. Travis Burgess, QB	★★★
8. Carnell Warren, WR	★★★
9. Jimmy-Phrisco Alo-Sulifu, DL	★★★
10. Vodney Cleveland, DL	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Bill Belichick - Record at School: 4-8 (1 year) - Career Record: 4-8 (1 year) - Offensive Coordinator: Bobby Petrino
Defensive Coordinator: Steve Belichick - Location: Chapel Hill, N.C. - Stadium: Kenan Stadium (50,500)



JORDAN SHIPP

SCOUTING THE TAR HEELS

"Schematically, it felt like a Bill Belichick defense. They do a really good job of using the people they have, mixing up who the rushers are, looking at who you are and how they want to match up to you. Week to week, they actually make better adjustments than a lot of people. They just didn't have the players. And they were better on defense than on offense. They were pretty bad on offense, but the guy they hired, Bobby Petrino, is phenomenal. He's as good of a coach as there is with offense in college football. I can't imagine how that dynamic [with Belichick] is gonna go, though. ... I don't think there's a sense that they've improved their evaluation abilities for this day and age of college football to bring in the right guys."

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	1	JORDAN SHIPP (JR.)	86	Madrid Tucker (Fr.)
WR	82	Nathan Leacock (Jr.)	4	Mason Humphrey* (Sr.)
WR	2	Trech Kekahuna* (Jr.)	11	Shanard Clower (So.)
LT	66	Jordan Hall (Jr.)	72	Eidan Buchanan (So.)
LG	68	Aidan Banfield (Jr.)	77	Trey Blue (Fr.)
C	56	Christo Kelly (Sr.)	69	Chad Lindberg (Sr.)
RG	54	Jonah Rodriguez* (Jr.)	70	Byron Nelson (Fr.)
RT	71	Jacqawn McRoy* (So.)	75	Andrew Threatt* (Sr.)
TE	45	Jelani Thurman* (Jr.)	80	Jordan Washington* (So.)
QB	9	Billy Edwards Jr.* (Sr.)	8	Miles O'Neill* (So.)
RB	0	DEMON JUNE (SO.)	7	Benjamin Hall (Jr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	40	Donovan Hoilette Jr.* (Sr.)	25	Joseph Mupoyi (So.)
DT	0	Isaiah Johnson (Sr.)	90	Xavier Lewis (So.)
DT	91	LEROY JACKSON (SO.)	14	Tarvorise Brown* (Jr.)
DE	9	MELKART ABOU JAOUDE (SR.)	11	Jaylen Harvey* (So.)
LB	10	Peyton Seelmann* (Jr.)	8	Jonathan Agumadu (So.)
LB	15	Derek McDonald* (Sr.)	54	Timir Hickman-Collins (So.)
CB	18	Jaiden Patterson (Jr.)	4	Jalon Thompson (Jr.)
CB	3	Ade Willie* (Sr.)	5	Ty Adams (Jr.)
NB	2	KALEB COST (SR.)	6	Tre Miller (Jr.)
S	16	Coleman Bryson (Sr.)	7	Peyton Waters (So.)
S	1	Greg Smith (So.)	24	Javion Butts (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	92	Aeron Burrell* (Jr.)	KR	27	Jaylen McGill (So.)
P	93	Jacob Horvath (Jr.)	PR	11	Shanard Clower (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD - *2026 TRANSFER



CJ BAILEY

SCOUTING THE WOLFPACK

"They've always been able to recruit some of those edgier kids. When they get off the bus, they look like Clemson or they look like Florida State. It seems like every year with them, the hype has been really big, then it falls off quickly at some point. I don't know why that's the case. ... I don't think they really have the funds to compete at a high level in the ACC. For a while, they could feed off the great players they had there with the Russell Wilsons, the Mario Williams-type guys. But I don't get the sense that they have super deep pockets and that they're able to be competitive with NIL."

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	16	Davion Dozier* (Jr.)	82	Chance Robinson* (So.)
WR	2	Joshisa Trader* (Jr.)	85	Tyreek Copper (Fr.)
WR	8	Keenan Jackson (Jr.)	13	Tyran Warren* (Sr.)
LT	62	Jimarion McCrimmon* (Jr.)	56	Brody Smith (Fr.)
LG	72	Spike Sowell Jr. (So.)	79	Kamen Smith (Jr.)
C	50	Daniel Cruz* (So.)	72	Spike Sowell Jr. (So.)
RG	64	RICO JACKSON (JR.)	71	Yousef Mugharbil (Sr.)
RT	54	TEAGUE ANDERSEN (SR.)	74	Jai'Lun Hampton* (Sr.)
TE	19	Preston Douglas (So.)	88	Vander Ploog* (Fr.)
QB	16	CJ BAILEY (JR.)	10	Will Wilson (So.)
RB	4	Jayden Scott (So.)	7	Davion Gause* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (2)

DE	92	Chase Bond (So.)	47	Adrian Farrow (So.)
NT	90	Josiah Victor (So.)	55	KaTron Evans* (Sr.)
DT	88	Isaiah Shirley (Jr.)	43	AJ Prim (Jr.)
JACK	5	Harvey Dyson* (Sr.)	25	Sterling Dixon (So.)
MLB	0	Popo Aguirre* (Sr.)	15	AJ Richardson (Jr.)
WLB	19	Da'Karri Nelson* (Jr.)	35	LaCorian Hodge (So.)
CB	20	Ondre Evans* (So.)	12	Caden Gordon (So.)
CB	7	Brian Nelson II (Jr.)	10	Ty White* (So.)
NB	22	JACKSON VICK (SR.)	8	Isaiah Crowell (Sr.)
SS	6	ASAAD BROWN JR. (SO.)	3	Tristan Teasdell (So.)
FS	16	King Mack* (Sr.)	2	Ronnie Royal III (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	94	Kanoah Vinesett (Sr.)	KR	4	Jayden Scott (So.)
P	96	Jackson Waller* (So.)	PR	0	Victor Snow (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



NC STATE WOLFPACK

NATIONAL FORECAST: 46 | ACC PREDICTION: 9 | 2025 RECORD: 8-5, 4-4 ACC

OFFENSE Quarterback CJ Bailey heads into his third year as the starting quarterback and his second with offensive coordinator Kurt Roper. Roper's unit scored 30.2 points per game in his first season at the controls, and he is looking to continue that upward trajectory. Bailey, meanwhile, is coming off an impressive sophomore season. He threw for 3,105 yards with 25 touchdowns and just nine interceptions on a 68.8% completion rate. The signal-caller is confident that he will continue to progress, but he'll have to do so with a mostly new cast of characters around him.

The Wolfpack lost their top rusher (Hollywood Smothers) to the transfer portal, and their five leading pass-catchers all departed as well. Bailey will lean on junior Keenan Jackson, who caught 28 passes for 281 yards and two scores last season, while the Pack's transfer portal class will have to do a lot of heavy lifting. Keep an eye out for Appalachian State transfer Davion Dozier and Miami (Fla.) transfers Chance Robinson and Joshisa "Jojo" Trader. Redshirt sophomore running back Jayden "Duke" Scott is ready to take the starting reins in the backfield.

DEFENSE NC State's defense is entering its second season with coordinator DJ Eliot, whose pressure-based found its footing as 2025 went along.

Sophomore nose tackle Josiah Victor is primed to anchor the line, while transfers Popo Aguirre from Miami (Fla.) and Da'Karri Nelson from Penn State will patrol the second level. Tulane transfer edge Harvey Dyson, who led the AAC with eight sacks in '25, headlines the pass rush.

On the back end, the Wolfpack have options. Cornerback Brian Nelson II is set to start in his second season with the program, while Georgia transfer Ondre Evans has likely earned the starting spot opposite him. The safety room has game reps up and down the depth chart. As of now, it appears that Penn State transfer King Mack will start, with Asaad Brown Jr., Tristan Teasdell and Ronnie Royal III fighting for the other spot.

SPECIALISTS NC State returns kicker Kanoah Vinesett, who was 5-for-6 on field-goal attempts (with a long of 51) and 48-for-49 on extra-point attempts a year ago. The Pack turned to the transfer portal for punter Jackson Waller (Arkansas State), who averaged 41.3 yards per attempt a year ago and placed 19 of his 59 punts inside the 20-yard line.

FINAL ANALYSIS NC State hopes to take a step forward in a critical season for the program. Bailey looks ready to make the third-year jump under center, and the program's two second-year coordinators are ready to build off the momentum they enjoyed at the end of 2025. Look for a defense that flies around the field, with a high-tempo offense to complement it.

2025 RESULTS (8-5, 4-4 ACC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 28	East Carolina	W	24-17	Aug. 29	vs. Virginia #	1. Amiri Acker, WR	★★★★
Sept. 6	Virginia	W	35-31	Sept. 12	Richmond	2. Tyreek Copper, WR	★★★★
Sept. 11	at Wake Forest	W	34-24	Sept. 19	at Vanderbilt	3. Stephen Brown, TE	★★★★
Sept. 20	at Duke	L	33-45	Sept. 26	Appalachian State	4. Damaad Lewis, EDGE	★★★
Sept. 27	Virginia Tech	L	21-23	Oct. 3	Louisville	5. Tex Vaughn, TE	★★★
Oct. 4	Campbell	W	56-10	Oct. 10	Wake Forest	6. Aiden Smalls, ATH	★★★
Oct. 11	at Notre Dame	L	7-36	Oct. 24	at Stanford	7. Jai Richburg, WR	★★★
Oct. 25	at Pitt	L	34-53	Oct. 31	Cal	8. Josh Warren Jr., EDGE	★★★
Nov. 1	Georgia Tech	W	48-36	Nov. 7	Duke	9. Jordyn Best, CB	★★★
Nov. 15	at Miami (Fla.)	L	7-41	Nov. 14	Syracuse	10. Tristen Hill, S	★★★
Nov. 21	Florida State	W	21-11	Nov. 21	at Florida State	*Per Rivals	
Nov. 29	North Carolina	W	42-19	Nov. 28	at North Carolina		
Dec. 19	vs. Memphis #	W	31-7	#Rio de Janeiro, Brazil			
#Gasparilla Bowl							
TEAM INFORMATION							
Head Coach: Dave Doeren • Record at School: 95-70 (13 years)							
Career Record: 118-74 (15 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Kurt Roper							
Defensive Coordinator: DJ Eliot • Location: Raleigh, N.C.							
Stadium: Carter-Finley Stadium (56,919)							



PITT PANTHERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 40 | ACC PREDICTION: 7 | 2025 RECORD: 8-5, 6-2 ACC

OFFENSE The quarterback position has been more Pitt stop than permanent in recent seasons. Now, along comes Mason Heintschel, a midseason revelation who fueled an 8-5 finish in 2025 with an “I’m Him” mentality. The lightly recruited freshman was summoned by head coach Pat Narduzzi after a 2-2 start and promptly went 5-0, putting the Panthers in the College Football Playoff conversation before late-season losses to Notre Dame and Miami (Fla.). He went 6-3 overall, a run that featured four consecutive road victories, four 300-yard passing games and two upsets of ranked opponents. The 6-foot-2 Ohio native threw for 2,354 yards with 16 touchdowns and a 63.6% completion rate.

Coordinator Kade Bell oversaw a unit that ranked 20th nationally in scoring (33.7 ppg) and passing (273.3 ypg), though the running game ranked 115th (117.2 ypg). Tailback Ja’Kyrian Turner emerged in the final five games with 127 rushing yards at Stanford, 201 at Georgia Tech and 93 vs. East Carolina in the Military Bowl. The true freshman had a team-high 745 rushing yards (5.3 per carry) with seven scores. Returners Keith Gouveia, Ryan Baer and BJ Williams lead the O-line.

Other than returning starter Cataurus Hicks (24 receptions, 422 yards, long of 84), the receiving corps is light on experience. FCS Western Carolina transfer Malik Knight, freshman Dylan Wester and sophomores Tony Kinsler and Bryce Yates must be quick studies.

DEFENSE Braylan Lovelace aims to become Pitt’s next iconic linebacker. He posted a career-best 80 tackles and returned an interception 100 yards for a touchdown in a win over Georgia Tech. The senior middle linebacker could pair nicely with rising star Cameron Lindsey, a former backup who posted 32 tackles, five for a loss, two sacks, a pass breakup and a forced fumble. Purdue transfer Alex Sanford Jr. will play extensively.

The line features returners Isaiah Neal, Nick James, Sean FitzSimmons and Jimmy Scott — a quartet that enabled Pitt to rank No. 8 nationally vs. the run. Hard-hitting safety Cruce Brookins (53 tackles, two interceptions) and corner Shawn Lee Jr. (four pass breakups) lead the secondary.

SPECIALISTS FCS transfers Sam Hunsaker (15-of-22 on field-goal attempts in two seasons at Northern Arizona) and Antonio Chadha (28-of-38 in two seasons at Western Illinois) will vie for placekicking duties. FCS Idaho State transfer Gabe Russo averaged 46.3 yards on 38 punts in ‘25.

FINAL ANALYSIS Much is expected of the 19-year-old Heintschel after he led Pitt to a second-place ACC finish and its most victories since ‘22. If the Panthers can take advantage of a four-game homestand to start the season, the momentum could once again lead to eight (or more) victories.

2025 RESULTS (8-5, 6-2 ACC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*					
Aug. 30	Duquesne	W	61-9	Sept. 5	Miami (Ohio)	1. Corey Dailey, QB	★★★★				
Sept. 6	Central Michigan	W	45-17	Sept. 12	UCF	2. Rodney Dunbar, WR	★★★★				
Sept. 13	at West Virginia (ot)	L	24-31	Sept. 17	Syracuse	3. Damon Ferguson Jr, RB	★★★★				
Sept. 27	Louisville	L	27-34	Sept. 26	Bucknell	4. Nick Howard, OT	★★★★				
Oct. 4	Boston College	W	48-7	Oct. 2	at Virginia Tech	5. Isaiah Simmons, LB	★★★★				
Oct. 11	at Florida State	W	34-31	Oct. 10	North Carolina	6. Marcus Jennings, LB	★★★★				
Oct. 18	at Syracuse	W	30-13	Oct. 17	at Boston College	7. Reston Lehman, LB	★★★★				
Oct. 25	NC State	W	53-34	Oct. 24	at Miami (Fla.)	8. Kentrail McRae, CB	★★★★				
Nov. 1	at Stanford	W	35-20	Oct. 31	Georgia Tech	9. Dylan Wester, WR	★★★★				
Nov. 15	Notre Dame	L	15-37	Nov. 13	Florida State	10. Da’Ron Barksdale, CB	★★★★				
Nov. 22	at Georgia Tech	W	42-28	Nov. 21	at Louisville						
Nov. 29	Miami (Fla.)	L	7-38	Nov. 28	at Cal						
Dec. 27	vs. East Carolina #	L	17-23								
#Military Bowl				*Per Rivals							
TEAM INFORMATION											
Head Coach: Pat Narduzzi • Record at School: 80-61 (11 years)											
Career Record: 80-61 (11 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Kade Bell											
Defensive Coordinator: Cory Sanders • Location: Pittsburgh, Pa.											
Stadium: Acrisure Stadium (68,400)											



MASON HEINTSCHEL

SCOUTING THE PANTHERS

“They’re a really good defensive team, and they’re adequate on offense, I guess. If you’ve got a Kenny Pickett, then you’re gonna be really good. I thought they did an awesome job with [quarterback Eli Holstein] the past two years. When they’re good, they’re really good, but they’re not that dynamic. I don’t know who you’re concerned about when they’re on offense. On defense, they’ve got good players, but they’re really great at what they do. It’s more like they’re coached really well and their players fit the system. They do create turnovers and things like that. ... They put [quarterback Mason Heintschel] in there, and they could just check it down to the running back all day. I do think they’re well-coached. I just don’t think that they’re elite anywhere on offense.”

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (5)

WR	18	Malik Knight* (Sr.)	17	Tony Kinsler (So.)
WR	3	CATAURUS HICKS (JR.)	10	Censere Lee (Sr.)
WR	80	Bryce Yates (So.)	84	Cam Sapp (Fr.)
LT	53	Kendall Stanley (Sr.)	74	Netinho Olivieri* (Sr.)
LG	66	Keith Gouveia (Sr.)	56	Keylen Davis* (Sr.)
C	71	RYAN CARRETTA (JR.)	72	Isaiah Montgomery (Sr.)
RG	55	BJ WILLIAMS (SR.)	68	Torian Chester (Fr.)
RT	70	RYAN BAER (SR.)	51	Jiavani Cooley (So.)
TE	85	Carson Kent (Sr.)	82	Elijah Lagg* (Sr.)
QB	6	MASON HEINTSCHEL (SO.)	11	Holden Gerner* (Sr.)
RB	25	Ja’Kyrian Turner (So.)	29	La’Vell Wright* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	2	ISAIAH NEAL (JR.)	56	Jaeden Moore (Jr.)
DL	55	SEAN FITZSIMMONS (SR.)	95	Eliyt Nairne* (Jr.)
DL	11	Nick James (Sr.)	45	Jeremiah Warren* (Jr.)
DE	44	JIMMY SCOTT (SR.)	5	Zach Crothers (So.)
LB	10	Alex Sanford Jr.* (Sr.)	31	DeMarco Ward* (Jr.)
LB	0	BRAYLAN LOVELACE (SR.)	52	Abe Ibrahim (Sr.)
LB	24	Cameron Lindsey (So.)	38	Emmanuel Taylor (So.)
CB	21	Shadarian Harrison (Jr.)	23	Kanye Thompson* (Sr.)
CB	28	Shawn Lee Jr. (So.)	16	Raion Strader* (Sr.)
SS	14	Josh Guerrier (So.)	26	Allen Bryant (So.)
FS	12	CRUCE BROOKINS (JR.)	17	Cole Woodson (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	91	Sam Hunsaker* (Jr.)	KR	3	Cataurus Hicks (Jr.)
P	98	Gabe Russo* (Jr.)	PR	3	Cataurus Hicks (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

CHARLES LECLAIRE-IMAGN IMAGES



KEVIN JENNINGS

SCOUTING THE MUSTANGS

"Man, [head coach Rhett Lashlee] does a great job. He's done such a great job the last several years, and the football world knows it, too. Any time one of these big jobs opens up, you're probably gonna hear Rhett's name. They do a great job with recruiting and the true evaluation of players. Just being able to get those guys in at that university — it's one of those high-academic schools that you have to be able to get in and stay in. ... I know a lot of the guys on SMU's staff, and I think [Lashlee's] coaches are some of the best that I've been around. He just knows how to evaluate people."

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	10	Jalen Cooper (So.)	3	Yannick Smith* (Jr.)
WR	2	Jalen Hale* (Jr.)	45	Isaiah Robertson (Fr.)
WR	8	Yamir Knight (Sr.)	0	Derrick McFall (So.)
LT	59	PJ WILLIAMS (SR.)	78	Drew Evers (Fr.)
LG	77	Alex Woods (Jr.)	58	Abel Hoopii (So.)
C	64	JOSHUA BATES (JR.)	50	Graham Uter (So.)
RG	63	ADDISON NICHOLS (SR.)	52	Toa Katoa (Fr.)
RT	74	Andrew Chamblee (Sr.)	75	Dramodd Odoms (Fr.)
TE	18	Theo Melin Ohrstrom* (Sr.)	5	Randy Pittman Jr.* (Sr.)
QB	7	KEVIN JENNINGS (SR.)	1	Ty Hawkins (Fr.)
RB	6	Kendrick Raphael* (Sr.)	4	Dramekco Green (Fr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	58	Aakil Washington (Sr.)	9	Ira Singleton IV* (Jr.)
DT	97	Christian Davis* (Jr.)	94	Jonathan Jefferson (Sr.)
DT	5	Malcolm Alcorn-Crowder* (Sr.)	55	Woo Spencer (Jr.)
DE	6	Tavion Atkinson* (Jr.)	52	Jahkai Lang (Jr.)
LB	54	ALEXANDER KILGORE (SR.)	29	Brandon Miyazono (Sr.)
LB	28	BRANDON BOOKER (JR.)	12	Caden Marshall* (So.)
CB	4	Jayvon Thomas* (Sr.)	0	WILLIAM NETTLES (SO.)
CB	8	MARCELLUS BARNES JR. (SO.)	13	Jaelyn Davis-Robinson (Sr.)
NB	1	Jarvis Lee* (Sr.)	15	La'Modrick Spencer (Sr.)
S	21	Jimmy Wyrick* (Sr.)	26	Jaylen Moses (So.)
S	10	Tyren Polley Jr. (So.)	22	Sael Reyes (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	99	Nick Reed* (Jr.)	KR	24	Link Rhodes (Sr.)
P	43	Wade McSparron (So.)	PR	8	Yamir Knight (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



SMU MUSTANGS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 22 | ACC PREDICTION: 2 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 6-2 ACC

OFFENSE Kevin Jennings returns at quarterback, but his group of tight ends, wide receivers and running backs is almost completely different. Jennings was injured in 2025, hampering his ability to run, but he took a step forward as a passer, ranking in the top 10 nationally for passing yards.

Alabama transfer Jalen Hale and East Carolina transfer Yannick Smith arrive to bolster the wide receiver room, while Jalen Cooper and Isaiah Robertson look to assert themselves in their second season at SMU. Yamir Knight is a dynamic slot receiver for Jennings. Cal transfer running back Kendrick Raphael is expected to pair with second-year back Dramekco Green to provide plenty of backfield production.

The offensive line is a strong unit, with three returning starters, including PJ Williams, who figures to be a high NFL Draft pick.

DEFENSE Last year, the SMU defense was all over the place, with moments of impressive play followed by huge game-changing lapses.

SMU brings back Marcellus Barnes Jr. and William "Speedy" Nettles at corner and Tyren Polley Jr. at safety, but the rest of the secondary has been revamped with transfers. UTSA safety Jimmy Wyrick, USF nickel Jarvis Lee and Texas A&M transfer cornerback Jayvon Thomas all are expected to make a major impact.

SMU returns an impressive trio of linebackers in Brandon Booker, Alexander Kilgore and Brandon Miyazono. Up front, SMU reworked the defensive line with Louisiana Tech transfer Christian Davis and Kansas State transfer Malcolm Alcorn-Crowder, and 2024 standout Jonathan Jefferson returns after missing all of the 2025 season due to injury.

Finding a pass rush from the likes of Aakil Washington, Ira Singleton IV, Tavion Atkinson, Marques White, Jahkai Lang and others will be critical.

SPECIALISTS Placekicking was an adventure for SMU last season, so the Mustangs brought in FCS New Hampshire All-American Nick Reed. Punter Wade McSparron and long-snapper Morgan Tribett return for the Mustangs. Knight is locked in as the punt returner, while kickoff returns are up for grabs a bit with Link Rhodes and Daylon Singleton both back.

FINAL ANALYSIS With Jennings back, SMU should be among the favorites to win the ACC championship. Head coach Rhett Lashlee's team has been among the nation's most consistent programs for the past few seasons, and expectations are as high now as they've ever been. Lashlee and his staff seemed to hit on transfers who could push the team over the top. If so, SMU could find itself back in Charlotte playing in the ACC Championship Game. It's College Football Playoff or bust for this team.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 6-2 ACC)

Aug. 30	East Texas A&M	W	42-13
Sept. 6	Baylor (ot)	L	45-48
Sept. 13	at Missouri State	W	28-10
Sept. 20	at TCU	L	24-35
Oct. 4	Syracuse	W	31-18
Oct. 11	Stanford	W	34-10
Oct. 18	at Clemson	W	35-24
Oct. 25	at Wake Forest	L	12-13
Nov. 1	Miami (ot)	W	26-20
Nov. 8	at Boston College	W	45-13
Nov. 22	Louisville	W	38-6
Nov. 29	at Cal	L	35-38
Jan. 2	vs. Arizona #	W	24-19

#Holiday Bowl

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 7	at Florida State
Sept. 12	UC Davis
Sept. 19	at Louisville
Sept. 26	Missouri State
Oct. 3	Boston College
Oct. 17	Virginia
Oct. 24	Cal
Oct. 31	at Syracuse
Nov. 7	Virginia Tech
Nov. 14	Wake Forest
Nov. 21	at Notre Dame
Nov. 28	at Stanford

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Drew Evers, IOL	★★★★
2. Christian Rhodes, RB	★★★★
3. EJ Kelly, RB	★★★★
4. Evan Goodwin, OT	★★★★
5. David Chukwuemeka, DL	★★★★
6. Amontre Harris, EDGE	★★★
7. Hudson Woods, EDGE	★★★
8. I'Zayah Young, LB	★★★
9. Sam Utu, IOL	★★★
10. Jakai Anderson, WR	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Rhett Lashlee • Record at School: 38-16 (4 years)
Career Record: 38-16 (4 years) • Offensive Coordinators: Garin Justice, D'Eriq King • Defensive Coordinators: Maurice Crum Jr., Rickey Hunley Jr.
Location: Dallas, Texas • Stadium: Gerald J. Ford Stadium (33,200)



STANFORD CARDINAL

NATIONAL FORECAST: 84 | ACC PREDICTION: 17 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 3-5 ACC

OFFENSE The Stanford offense will center around quarterback Davis Warren, running back Micah Ford, wide receiver Caden High and tight end Benji Blackburn. A veteran with starting experience at Michigan, Warren brings a good presence in the pocket, an ability to make plays with his legs and a knack for clutch throws. He threw for 1,199 yards, seven touchdowns and nine interceptions for the Wolverines in 2024.

Ford rushed for 643 yards and four touchdowns on 145 carries last season and could flirt with 1,000 rushing yards this season. High had 37 receptions for 414 yards and one touchdown last season, while Blackburn had nine receptions for 109 yards and one touchdown. Both guys should see plenty of targets and could make a real impact. It'll be interesting to see what new head coach Tavita Pritchard brings in terms of scheme.

Up front, Niki Prongos, Fisher Anderson and Simone Pale will anchor the offensive line. Their play will be critical in the Cardinal's quest for offensive balance.

DEFENSE Middle linebacker Matt Rose is the heart and soul of the Cardinal defense. He is coming off a season in which he had 106 total tackles (49 solo) and eight tackles for a loss. He should once again wreak havoc everywhere on the field.

The safety room is also strong with Jay Green, Scotty Edwards, Charlie Eckhardt and Darrius Davis. Cornerback Brandon Nicholson looks to take his game up a notch from last year.

On the defensive line, Braden Marceau-Olayinka and Zach Rowell should both be forces after making significant strides last season. The Cardinal played top-25-level defense in the red zone in 2025 and will look to keep that momentum going under new defensive coordinator Kris Richard.

SPECIALISTS Punter Aidan Flintoft and placekicker Emmet Kenney are both veteran guys with a lot of experience. The real question on special teams is whether or not the Cardinal can make some noise in the return game. High will look to do his part.

FINAL ANALYSIS Coming off a 4-8 season in which it defeated Cal to win the Stanford Axe, Stanford is hoping to build on what it did last year and take more steps forward in 2026. Given the Cardinal's schedule, they'll be hard pressed to win five-plus games, but the belief in the program's trajectory is there, spearheaded by Stanford alumni Andrew Luck (general manager) and Pritchard.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 3-5 ACC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 23	at Hawai'i	L	20-23	Aug. 29	Hawai'i	1. Lasiah Jackson, CB	★★★★
Sept. 6	at BYU	L	3-27	Sept. 4	Miami (Fla.)	2. Dre Pollard, ATH	★★★★
Sept. 13	Boston College	W	30-20	Sept. 19	at Duke	3. Jay Miller, IOL	★★★★
Sept. 20	at Virginia	L	20-48	Sept. 26	Georgia Tech	4. Max Meier, EDGE	★★★★
Sept. 27	San José State	W	30-29	Oct. 3	at Wake Forest	5. Zion Robinson, WR	★★★
Oct. 11	at SMU	L	10-34	Oct. 10	at Notre Dame	6. Langdon Horace, WR	★★★
Oct. 18	Florida State	W	20-13	Oct. 17	Elon	7. Xavier Harmon, CB	★★★
Oct. 25	at Miami (Fla.)	L	7-42	Oct. 24	NC State	8. Mike Mitchell Jr., QB	★★★
Nov. 1	Pitt	L	20-35	Oct. 31	at Louisville	9. Keysaun Eleazer, EDGE	★★★
Nov. 8	at North Carolina	L	15-20	Nov. 14	at Virginia Tech	10. Blaise Thomassie, IOL	★★★
Nov. 22	Cal	W	31-10	Nov. 21	at Cal		
Nov. 29	Notre Dame	L	20-49	Nov. 28	SMU		

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Tavita Pritchard • Record at School: First Season • Career Record: First Season • Offensive Coordinator: Terry Heffernan • Defensive Coordinator: Kris Richard • Location: Palo Alto, Calif. • Stadium: Stanford Stadium (50,424)



JAY GREEN

SCOUTING THE CARDINAL

"The direction that they went with [new head coach] Tavita Pritchard and obviously with [general manager] Andrew Luck being there, just having those guys in the building after they cried, sweat, bled in those same locker rooms and on that same field, that's gonna give those guys a bit of an edge. Knowing that they got someone there from home to be leading them, it's just like what Cal has with [new head coach] Tosh Lupoi being there. ... Their recruiting is still so much more on the academic side. Like it's truly, 'we're a better school because of academics.' That's the only thing I would ever hear about what they were doing."

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (5)

WR	0	Caden High (Sr.)	23	Nico Brown* (Jr.)
WR	19	David Pantelis (Sr.)	4	Jordan Onovughe (Jr.)
WR	11	JonAnthony Hall (Fr.)	15	Carter Shaw (So.)
LT	68	NIKI PRONGOS (SR.)	79	Kai Greer (So.)
LG	60	Nick Fattig (Jr.)	59	Charlie Hoitink (So.)
C	74	FISHER ANDERSON (SR.)	63	Carson Caplan (Fr.)
RG	55	SIMIONE PALE (SR.)	62	Josh Williams (So.)
RT	58	KAHLIL HOUSE (SO.)	51	Ziron Brown (So.)
TE	88	Benji Blackburn (Jr.)	84	Chico Holt (Jr.)
QB	8	Davis Warren* (Sr.)	9	Mike Mitchell Jr. (Fr.)
RB	20	MICAH FORD (SO.)	26	Sedrick Irvin Jr. (Sr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	45	Omar Staples (Jr.)	95	Adam Shovlin (Fr.)
DT	75	Braden Marceau-Olayinka (Jr.)	42	Jacobi Murray (So.)
DT	97	Zach Rowell (Sr.)	96	Connor Bachhuber (So.)
OLB	11	TEVARUA TAFITI (SR.)	2	Dylan Stephenson (So.)
ILB	35	MATT ROSE (SR.)	38	Zach Johnson (Jr.)
ILB	0	JAHSIAH GALVAN (SR.)	10	Sam Mattingly (Jr.)
OLB	44	Ernest "R.J." Cooper (Sr.)	88	Keysaun Eleazer (Fr.)
CB	9	Brandon Nicholson (So.)	8	Cam Richardson (Jr.)
CB	4	Leroy Bryant* (Jr.)	14	Dre Pollard (Fr.)
S	21	SCOTTY EDWARDS (SR.)	29	Darrius Davis (Jr.)
S	5	JAY GREEN (SR.)	39	Charlie Eckhardt (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	13	Emmet Kenney (Sr.)	KR	0	Caden High (Sr.)
P	37	Aidan Flintoft (Sr.)	PR	13	Liam Thorpe (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



STEVE ANGELI

SCOUTING THE ORANGE

"If [quarterback] Steve Angeli is healthy, it'll be fixed. It's really what it comes down to. I don't know if the other guys in that room are any good. But [Angeli] is really good. ... [Head coach] Fran Brown is a good leader. If he sticks to his strengths, he'll do fine. He does a good job running that program. He does a good job evaluating. Hopefully the overhaul of the staff will help him tremendously, especially on the defensive side. On the offensive side, I don't really know the receivers they brought in, but there's some talent still there. They let some good players go, and I know they changed ADs, but I think [Brown] is in good shape there. I don't think they're a place that wants to spend a lot of money to get rid of a coach unless they just bomb it."

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	2	Umari Hatcher (Sr.)	17	Elijah Moore* (So.)
WR	11	Cole Weaver* (Jr.)	15	Amare' Gough (Fr.)
WR	8	Tyshawn Russell (Jr.)	14	Zamondre Merriweather (Jr.)
LT	75	TREVION MACK (JR.)	60	Naquil Betrand (Jr.)
LG	69	Oluwafunto Akinshilo* (Sr.)	55	Zach Rice (Sr.)
C	78	JOE CRUZ (SR.)	74	Matthew Hawn (Fr.)
RG	76	Byron Washington (So.)	71	Jayden Mann (Fr.)
RT	77	Kam Pringle (So.)		David Ndukwe* (Sr.)
TE	0	David Clement (Sr.)	81	Noah Meyers* (Jr.)
QB	9	STEVE ANGELI (SR.)	12	Amari Odom* (Jr.)
RB	4	Ju'Juan Johnson* (Jr.)	22	Ahmad Miller* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	30	Tunmise Adeleye* (Sr.)	18	David Omopariola (Jr.)
DT	14	Keyshawn Johnson* (Sr.)	15	Nathan Nyandoro (So.)
DT	92	Rashard Perry (Sr.)	11	Nissi Ogbobor (So.)
DT	95	Dillan Fontus* (Sr.)	99	Isaiah Hastings (Sr.)
LB	6	Chris D'Appolonia* (Jr.)	2	Zyian Moultrie-Goddard (Jr.)
LB	5	ANTOINE DESLAURIERS (SO.)	10	GARY BRYANT III (SR.)
LB	82	Jamie Tremble (Jr.)	33	Gemaus Sackie (Fr.)
CB	1	DEMETRES SAMUEL JR. (SO.)	27	Javon Lawrence (Fr.)
CB	12	CHRIS PEAL (JR.)	4	Chase Geter (Fr.)
S	0	Braheem Long Jr. (Jr.)	19	CORNELL PERRY (SR.)
S	7	Nazir Ward* (Jr.)	13	Amare Snowden* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	47	Tripp Woody (So.)	KR	1	Demetres Samuel Jr. (So.)
P	41	Jimmy Gregg (Fr.)	PR	1	Demetres Samuel Jr. (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



SYRACUSE ORANGE

NATIONAL FORECAST: 71 | ACC PREDICTION: 15 | 2025 RECORD: 3-9, 1-7 ACC

OFFENSE Syracuse was 3-1 when quarterback Steve Angeli was ruled out for the 2025 season due to a torn Achilles tendon. The Orange finished 3-9, failing to score more than 18 points in any of the eight losses that followed. If the Fran Brown era is to be rejuvenated in 2026, it will almost certainly be on the back of his star quarterback. Angeli, who started his career at Notre Dame (2023-24) and was leading the nation in passing yards (1,317) at the time of his injury, was a limited participant during spring practice but is expected to be ready for fall camp.

Around Angeli will be a committee of skill-position players, including a bevy of transfers. SU doesn't return anyone who recorded more than 130 rushing or receiving yards last year. And it doesn't help that 5-star freshman WR Calvin Russell III suffered a torn Achilles of his own in March. Former LSU running back Ju'Juan Johnson and Miami (Ohio) wide receiver Cole Weaver will be among the newcomers getting significant early opportunities.

Up front, the Orange feature an experienced offensive line bolstered by the addition of Houston transfer David Ndukwe.

DEFENSE A step forward on defense starts in the trenches for Syracuse, and a trio of transfers in Dillan Fontus (Maryland), Keyshawn Johnson (FCS UT-Martin) and Tunmise Adeleye (UNLV) is expected to provide an immediate boost. The Orange allowed 5.3 yards per carry last season — ranking 132nd of 136 teams in the FBS.

But under new defensive coordinator Vince Kehres, the reloaded defensive line room should have the personnel to fit into what's expected to be a variable scheme featuring 4-3 and 3-4 bases.

The question is whether the Orange can execute in run fits and avoid miscommunications on the back end in Year 1 of the system. Interior linebackers like Chris D'Appolonia and Antoine Deslauriers will be tasked with leading communication, while SU's corners project to take on heavy man-coverage assignments.

SPECIALISTS Tripp Woody returns as placekicker after making 12-of-14 field goals last season, including all 10 of his attempts inside 40 yards. But SU must replace standout punter Jack Stonehouse, likely hoping that highly touted prospect Jimmy Gregg can hit the ground running.

FINAL ANALYSIS Brown's dazzling 10-3 debut campaign is fading into the rearview faster by the day, and the reality is that winning in Syracuse over the past quarter-century has hinged on QB play. Keeping Angeli upright is priority No. 1, while preparing transfer quarterback additions Amari Odom (Kennesaw State) and Malachi Nelson (UTEP) is right behind.

2025 RESULTS (3-9, 1-7 ACC)

Aug. 30	vs. Tennessee #	L	26-45
Sept. 6	UConn (ot)	W	27-20
Sept. 12	Colgate	W	66-24
Sept. 20	at Clemson	W	34-21
Sept. 27	Duke	L	3-38
Oct. 4	at SMU	L	18-31
Oct. 18	Pitt	L	13-30
Oct. 25	at Georgia Tech	L	16-41
Oct. 31	North Carolina	L	10-27
Nov. 8	at Miami (Fla.)	L	10-38
Nov. 22	at Notre Dame	L	7-70
Nov. 29	Boston College	L	12-34

#Atlanta

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	New Hampshire
Sept. 12	Cal
Sept. 17	at Pitt
Oct. 3	at UConn
Oct. 10	at Virginia
Oct. 17	Louisville
Oct. 24	at North Carolina
Oct. 31	SMU
Nov. 7	Clemson
Nov. 14	at NC State
Nov. 21	at Boston College
Nov. 28	Notre Dame

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1.	Calvin Russell III, WR	★★★★
2.	Tedarius Hughes, S	★★★
3.	Javeion Cooper, OT	★★★
4.	Jarius Rodgers, EDGE	★★★
5.	Chase Geter, CB	★★★
6.	Joseph White, OT	★★★
7.	Kamron Wilson, EDGE	★★★
8.	Amare' Gough, WR	★★★
9.	Alex Haskell, DL	★★★
10.	Darnell Stokes Jr., ATH	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Fran Brown • Record at School: 13-12 (2 years)
Career Record: 13-12 (2 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Jeff Nixon
Defensive Coordinators: Vince Kehres, John Scott Jr.
Location: Syracuse, N.Y. • Stadium: JMA Wireless Dome (42,784)



VIRGINIA CAVALIERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 39 | ACC PREDICTION: 6 | 2025 RECORD: 11-3, 7-1 ACC

OFFENSE Virginia's offseason mission prioritized the retention of its veteran offensive line, and that unit is the Cavaliers' backbone heading into the fall. Projected starters McKale Boley, Noah Josey, Drake Metcalf, Makilan Thomas and Monroe Mills have combined for 164 career starts, making UVA's O-line the most experienced in the nation. The Hoos want to run behind that group. Boley and Josey were All-ACC performers in 2025, helping UVA rush for 2,502 yards, the program's most since 2004.

UVA is deep at running back even though they're replacing J'Mari Taylor, a first-team All-ACC performer. Tennessee transfer Peyton Lewis has the most elite combination of size and speed for a running back that the Cavaliers have had in fifth-year head coach Tony Elliott's tenure. Middle Tennessee transfer Jekail Middlebrook will get plenty of touches, and Xavier Brown and UAB transfer Solomon Beebe are capable contributors.

Quarterback Beau Pribula, a Missouri transfer, will factor into the running game, too. But Pribula must progress as a passer. He was third in the SEC in completion rate (67.4%) last fall, but his touchdown-to-interception ratio was 11-to-9. He must reduce his turnovers.

Some new receivers must emerge after the Cavaliers lost six of their top seven receptions leaders from last fall.

DEFENSE UVA is strongest up the middle, where the headliner is linebacker Kam Robinson. Last season, he became the first FBS player in 20 years to block a punt, return an interception for a touchdown and recover a fumble in the same season, although he missed six games due to a broken collarbone and torn ACL. UVA needs him healthy. Maddox Marcellus filled in admirably for Robinson last year, and now they'll be paired as starters.

Defensive tackles Jason Hammond and Anthony Britton both enter their fourth seasons, and the Cavaliers expect Michigan transfer Brandy Hillman to be the squad's next productive safety. At UVA, he'll step into the role previously occupied by Devin Neal Jr. last year and by Jonas Sanker in 2024. Both former UVA safeties led the team in tackles in those seasons. Fisher Camac (6-7, 253) is the Cavaliers' best pass-rusher.

SPECIALISTS Placekicker Will Bettridge and punter Daniel Sparks give UVA trusted fifth-year starters at those spots. Beebe and Jacquon Gibson are slated to handle returns.

FINAL ANALYSIS UVA set a school record with 11 wins last season, and Elliott's bunch will be a factor again because of its excellent O-line and deep backfield and because defensive coordinator John Rudzinski can mold his unit quickly. What could hurt the Hoos is if their wide receivers don't pan out and the passing game flops.

2025 RESULTS (11-3, 7-1 ACC)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 Coastal Carolina W 48-7	Aug. 29 vs. NC State #	1. Dylan Cope, WR ★★★
Sept. 6 at NC State L 31-35	Sept. 12 Norfolk State	2. Dallas Brannon, LB ★★★
Sept. 13 William & Mary W 55-16	Sept. 19 vs. West Virginia %	3. Alex Dunn, CB ★★★
Sept. 20 Stanford W 48-20	Sept. 26 Delaware	4. Mikey Gildea, IOL ★★★
Sept. 26 Florida State (ot) W 46-38	Oct. 3 at Florida State	5. Derek Uran, LB ★★★
Oct. 4 at Louisville (ot) W 30-27	Oct. 10 Syracuse	6. DaMari Carter, ATH ★★★
Oct. 18 Washington State W 22-20	Oct. 17 at SMU	7. Bull Richardson, DL ★★★
Oct. 25 at North Carolina (ot) W 17-16	Oct. 24 Duke	8. Jayden Covil, CB ★★★
Nov. 1 at Cal W 31-21	Oct. 31 at Wake Forest	9. Luke Hatfield, IOL ★★★
Nov. 8 Wake Forest L 9-16	Nov. 14 Cal	10. Jack Rhodes, WR ★★★
Nov. 15 at Duke W 34-17	Nov. 21 North Carolina	
Nov. 29 Virginia Tech W 27-7	Nov. 28 at Virginia Tech	
Dec. 6 vs. Duke # (ot) L 20-27	% Charlotte, NC #Rio de Janeiro, Brazil	*Per Rivals
Dec. 27 vs. Missouri % W 13-7		
#Charlotte %Gator Bowl		
TEAM INFORMATION		
Head Coach: Tony Elliott • Record at School: 22-26 (4 years)		
Career Record: 22-26 (4 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Des Kitchings		
Defensive Coordinator: John Rudzinski • Location: Charlottesville, Va.		
Stadium: Scott Stadium (61,500)		



MADDOX MARCELLUS

SCOUTING THE CAVALIERS

"I'm a fan. Stock up on them. I've heard good things about their NIL and the way that they're structuring things. They've got a really unique incentive package for how they're gonna do stuff to be sustainable and not have to pay boatloads of money up front to anyone, even if they're a good player, but that it was still going to be able to incentivize guys to come while motivating them to get on the field. ... [Missouri transfer quarterback] Beau Pribula is a good complement to any QB room. I felt like he was a great add for them, especially considering the dual-threat ability they asked of their QB last year. Now that he has some experience, I think he'll take the next step, especially in the offense that they run."

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	11	Rico Flores Jr.* (Sr.)	84	Isaiah Robinson (So.)
WR	15	Dillon Newton-Short (So.)	18	Da'Shawn Martin* (Jr.)
WR	5	Kameron Courtney (Jr.)	19	Jacquon Gibson* (Sr.)
LT	52	MCKALE BOLEY (SR.)	72	Ben York (Jr.)
LG	77	NOAH JOSEY (SR.)	64	Cole Surber (Sr.)
C	60	DRAKE METCALF (SR.)	69	Ryan Brubaker* (Sr.)
RG	54	Makilan Thomas (Sr.)	65	Grant Ellinger (Jr.)
RT	71	Monroe Mills (Sr.)	79	Jon Adair (So.)
TE	9	Dakota Twitty (Sr.)	89	John Rogers (So.)
QB	7	Beau Pribula* (Sr.)	10	Eli Holstein* (Sr.)
RB	2	Peyton Lewis* (Jr.)	21	Jekail Middlebrook* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	16	Matthew Fobbs-White* (Sr.)	33	Nnanna Anyanwu* (Sr.)
DT	91	JASON HAMMOND (SR.)	44	Darrion Henry-Young* (Sr.)
DT	55	Anthony Britton (Sr.)	54	Zion Wilson* (Sr.)
DE	14	FISHER CAMAC (SR.)	94	Ezekiel Larry* (Sr.)
LB	5	KAM ROBINSON (SR.)	26	Caleb Hardy (Sr.)
LB	11	Maddox Marcellus (Sr.)	32	Landon Danley (Sr.)
SPUR	4	Corey Costner (So.)	23	Jaylen Jones* (Sr.)
CB	10	Jacobie Henderson* (Sr.)	9	Jam Jackson (Sr.)
CB	2	DONAVON PLATT (SR.)	20	Omillio Agard* (Jr.)
S	6	Brandy Hillman* (Sr.)	18	Jalen McNair* (Sr.)
S	30	ETHAN MINTER (JR.)	8	Christian Ellis* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	41	Will Bettridge (Sr.)	KR	28	Solomon Beebe* (Jr.)
P	38	Daniel Sparks (Sr.)	PR	19	Jacquon Gibson* (Sr.)

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KEMARI COPELAND

SCOUTING THE HOKIES

"The blueprint that [new head coach] James Franklin has had in his career from Vandy to Penn State translates very well to that league. Virginia Tech should be one of the top three programs in the ACC when done right. I'm excited to see what they do because I've got a ton of belief in the recruits they brought in and the infrastructure that's in place for them to be successful. ... The level of respect that I have for the humbleness and lack of ego that [former head coach] Brent Pry has to [stay on as defensive coordinator] is off the charts. I don't think enough can be said about how special and how difficult that kind of a move is. Being able to take the head coach duties off his plate again might provide better defensive production."

—An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (8)

WR	0	AYDEN GREENE (SR.)	15	Snook Peterkin (So.)
WR	3	Que'Sean Brown* (Jr.)	5	Marlion Jackson* (Sr.)
WR	2	TAKYE HEATH (JR.)	6	Keylen Adams (So.)
LT	70	Logan Howland* (Jr.)	72	Justin Terry* (So.)
LG	56	LAYTH GHANNAM (JR.)	54	Michael Troutman III (Fr.)
C	62	KYLE ALTUNER (SO.)	53	Tommy Ricard (So.)
RG	77	Brody Meadows (Sr.)	79	JOHNNY GARRETT (SR.)
RT	66	Montavious Cunningham (Sr.)	76	AIDAN LYNCH (SO.)
TE	85	Luke Reynolds* (Jr.)	82	BENJI GOSNELL (SR.)
QB	17	Ethan Grunkemeyer* (So.)	22	Bryce Baker* (Fr.)
RB	27	MARCELLOUS HAWKINS (SR.)	16	Jeffrey Overton Jr. (Fr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	42	Ayden Stevens (Jr.)	31	Jason Abbey (Jr.)
DT	13	KEMARI COPELAND (SR.)	99	Emmett Laws (So.)
DT	94	Elhadj Fall (Sr.)	45	Eric Mensah* (So.)
DE	37	Mylachi Williams* (So.)	40	Javion Hilson* (Fr.)
OLB	33	Keon Wylie* (Jr.)	12	Gabe Williams (So.)
ILB	3	Kaleb Spencer (Sr.)	30	Curtis Jones Jr.* (Jr.)
ILB	16	NOAH CHAMBERS (SO.)	41	George Ballance (Jr.)
CB	9	ISAIAH BROWN-MURRAY (SR.)	5	Joshua Clarke (So.)
CB	2	Jaquez White* (Jr.)	22	Kenny Woseley Jr.* (So.)
S	0	QUENTIN REDDISH (SO.)	6	Jordan Bass (Sr.)
S	11	TYSON FLOWERS (SR.)	14	Sheldon Robinson (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	17	John Love (Sr.)	KR	23	Thomas Williams (Jr.)
P	95	Nathan Totten* (Jr.)	PR	3	Que'Sean Brown* (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



VIRGINIA TECH HOKIES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 30 | ACC PREDICTION: 5 | 2025 RECORD: 3-9, 2-6 ACC

OFFENSE New head coach James Franklin has a familiar face leading his offense, bringing quarterback Ethan Grunkemeyer with him from Penn State. Though Grunkemeyer didn't ascend to a starting spot until after Franklin's ouster, he acquitted himself well, throwing for 777 yards, six touchdowns and no picks in the Nittany Lions' final four games.

He'll have some intriguing weapons, with Ayden Greene back as the top wideout and the shifty Que'Sean Brown (846 receiving yards, five TDs last year) transferring from Duke. Running back Marcellous Hawkins quietly ranked fifth in the ACC at 6.35 yards per carry last year, and Penn State transfer tight end Luke Reynolds is a former 5-star recruit.

As usual, it could come down to the offensive line, which struggled to protect the quarterback last year but should be better under the instruction of second-year position coach Matt Moore. Center Kyle Altuner locks down the middle, but every other spot feels up for grabs.

DEFENSE Meet the new boss, same as the old boss. Brent Pry is back with the school that fired him last September as head coach. He's reunited with Franklin in a coordinator role, a partnership that served both of them well in Happy Valley.

Weight room stud Kemari Copeland (7.5 tackles for a loss, 4.5 sacks in 2025) gives the Hokies a building block on the interior line, and the secondary is beefed up. Quentin Reddish returns from a shoulder injury to headline the safeties room, while Tech restocked at corner, adding Jaquez White (Troy) and Kenny Woseley Jr. (Penn State) as transfers and getting Joshua Clarke back from a torn ACL. Expect the pass defense to improve upon its national ranking of 81st nationally in yards allowed.

There are question marks at linebacker and on the front. Sophomore Noah Chambers has hard-hitting upside in the middle, but there are few proven playmakers other than Copeland in the front seven.

SPECIALISTS John Love returns as one of the nation's top placekickers, a two-time All-ACC honorable mention selection who has made 84.4% of his career field-goal attempts and has booted five from 50-plus in the past two years. Brown could kickstart a stagnant punt return.

FINAL ANALYSIS It's been 10 years since Virginia Tech has played for an ACC championship and 16 years since it has won one — far too long for a program of the Hokies' caliber. By fortuitous timing, a recruiting-savvy, proven winner from the mid-Atlantic happened to be available on the coaching market last fall. It might take Franklin more than a year to make the Hokies a contender, but with his history and Tech's recent cash infusion to athletics, the days of going 3-9 feel over.

2025 RESULTS (3-9, 2-6 ACC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 31	vs. South Carolina #	L	11-24	Sept. 5	VMI	1. Terry Wiggins, LB	★★★★
Sept. 6	Vanderbilt	L	20-44	Sept. 12	Old Dominion	2. Tyson Harley, EDGE	★★★★
Sept. 13	Old Dominion	L	26-45	Sept. 19	at Maryland	3. Pierce Petersohn, TE	★★★★
Sept. 20	Wofford	W	38-6	Sept. 26	at Boston College	4. Zaezion Cleveland, CB	★★★★
Sept. 27	at NC State	W	23-21	Oct. 2	Pitt	5. Buddy Wegdam, OT	★★★★
Oct. 4	Wake Forest	L	23-30	Oct. 10	at Cal	6. Messiah Mickens, RB	★★★★
Oct. 11	at Georgia Tech	L	20-35	Oct. 17	Georgia Tech	7. Marlen Bright, OT	★★★★
Oct. 24	Cal (ot)	W	42-34	Oct. 24	at Clemson	8. Mathieu Lamah, LB	★★★★
Nov. 1	Louisville	L	16-28	Nov. 7	at SMU	9. T-Ron Richardson Jr., DL	★★★★
Nov. 15	at Florida State	L	14-34	Nov. 14	Stanford	10. Troy Huhn, QB	★★★★
Nov. 22	Miami (Fla.)	L	17-34	Nov. 20	at Miami (Fla.)		
Nov. 29	at Virginia	L	7-27	Nov. 28	Virginia		
			#Atlanta				*Per Rivals
TEAM INFORMATION							
Head Coach: James Franklin • Record at School: First Season							
Career Record: 128-60 (14+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Ty Howle							
Defensive Coordinator: Brent Pry • Location: Blacksburg, Va.							
Stadium: Lane Stadium (65,632)							

OFFENSE Gone is a quarterback duo that could be erratic; in steps a quarterback who was erratic for a different ACC team. Gio Lopez is set to reunite with Rob Ezell, his offensive coordinator at South Alabama in 2024 and current coordinator at Wake Forest. The 2024 version of Lopez was responsible for more than 3,000 yards of offense and 25 touchdowns. And if Lopez can recapture that form under Ezell's tutelage, his rough one-season stint at North Carolina will be forgotten.

Wake Forest has to solve the puzzle of who's blocking in front of him. Clinton Richard is a good building block, and there's no shortage of options up front — but there's work to be done in figuring out the top five.

The Deacons also have to replace plenty of lost production at wide receiver, where only Carlos Hernandez returns, and at running back, where Demond Claiborne is a significant loss. But there's plenty of speed and potential with transfer wide receivers Ny Carr, Chase Tyler, Wondame Davis Jr. and Kam Shanks.

DEFENSE This unit was the strength of last year's team, and that's probably the case again. Wake Forest returns both starting ends, Gabe Kirschke and Langston Hardy, who combined for 12 sacks and 26 tackles for a loss last year. There's also plenty of experience returning to the defensive tackle and linebacker spots.

On the back end, Davaughn Patterson is a budding star at nickel. Replacing two cornerbacks will be tough, but there are plenty of options, both with returning players and transfers. Getting Rushaun Tongue back from injury will help offset the loss of program pillar Nick Andersen.

SPECIALISTS Punting was a glaring issue last year. Ethan Hyams, from Australia, will get a crack at solidifying the position. Connor Calvert was excellent as a redshirt freshman kicker. He made 18-of-22 field-goal attempts, including a walk-off winner against SMU. Wake Forest was dynamic in the return game and should have no shortage of options despite losing Chris Barnes.

FINAL ANALYSIS Wake Forest won more games in head coach Jake Dickert's first season (nine) than it had in the previous two seasons combined (four in each). Following up an impressive first season with an equal or better year will be tough — and might be impossible if Lopez is the same rattled QB he was for most of last season.

Unlike many Wake teams of old, though, the Deacons can rely on their defense. On paper, this team checks all the boxes — experience, depth, size, speed — and should be able to grind out some close wins.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 4-4 ACC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 29	Kennesaw State	W	10-9	Sept. 3	Akron	1. Grant Lawless, QB	★★★★
Sept. 6	Western Carolina	W	42-10	Sept. 12	at Purdue	2. Kyndall McCaleb, RB	★★★★
Sept. 11	NC State	L	24-34	Sept. 18	Miami (Fla.)	3. Micheal Ahoua, LB	★★★★
Sept. 27	Georgia Tech (ot)	L	29-30	Sept. 26	at Louisville	4. Lucas Smalls-Allen, DL	★★★★
Oct. 4	at Virginia Tech	W	30-23	Oct. 3	Stanford	5. Monroe Partin, ATH	★★★★
Oct. 11	at Oregon State	W	39-14	Oct. 10	at NC State	6. Langston Hogg, IOL	★★★
Oct. 25	SMU	W	13-12	Oct. 17	at Cal	7. Sefa Sackey, EDGE	★★★
Nov. 1	at Florida State	L	7-42	Oct. 31	Virginia	8. Deuce Lawrence, RB	★★★
Nov. 8	at Virginia	W	16-9	Nov. 7	Merrimack	9. Mahamadou Siby, CB	★★★
Nov. 15	North Carolina	W	28-12	Nov. 14	at SMU	10. Walker Bryson, ATH	★★★
Nov. 22	Delaware	W	52-14	Nov. 21	at Georgia Tech		
Nov. 29	at Duke	L	32-49	Nov. 28	Duke		
Jan. 2	vs. Mississippi State #W	43-29					
#Duke's Mayo Bowl				TEAM INFORMATION			
				Head Coach: Jake Dickert • Record at School: 9-4 (1 year)			
				Career Record: 32-24 (5 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Rob Ezell			
				Defensive Coordinator: Scottie Hazelton • Location: Winston-Salem, N.C.			
				Stadium: Allegacy Federal Credit Union Stadium (31,500)			



CARLOS HERNANDEZ

SCOUTING THE DEMON DEACONS

"They're in a really good situation financially. They raised all of this money for new facilities right as NIL was starting to percolate. That's allowed them to be incredibly competitive with paying guys. They'd have third-string guys making \$150K. I know now, they're a lot more proactive with giving money to guys who aren't reaching out than they were even a few years ago. ... I've heard a lot of good things about [new head coach] Jake Dickert. People seem to really like what he's doing. He seems incredibly genuine. He's high energy, and he brings other high-energy, genuine guys around him. Their defensive line coach, T.J. Hollowell, he's as good as they get in the business. I say stock up on them. I wouldn't bet against those guys."

— An opposing ACC assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	9	Chase Tyler* (So.)	10	Jack Foley (Fr.)
WR	8	CARLOS HERNANDEZ (SR.)	5	Kam Shanks* (Jr.)
WR	11	Ny Carr* (So.)	7	Wondame Davis Jr.* (So.)
LT	67	Elliot Demaine (Fr.)	73	GEORGE STEIH (JR.)
LG	65	Clinton Richard (So.)	64	Ryan Berger* (Jr.)
C	70	Will Way* (Jr.)	51	Devin McRae (Jr.)
RG	74	John Ohnegian* (Sr.)	62	Jaishaun Offutt (Fr.)
RT	55	Tolu Olajide* (Sr.)	72	Aidan Martin (Fr.)
TE	12	Kamrean Johnson (Sr.)	81	Landon Morris* (Sr.)
QB	3	Gio Lopez* (Jr.)	6	Steele Pizzella (Fr.)
RB	4	Ty Clark III (Jr.)	1	KD Daniels* (So.)

DEFENSE (8)

DE	10	GABE KIRSCHKE (SR.)	14	Tyler Walton (Jr.)
DT	94	ZACH LOHAVICHAN (SR.)	99	Josiah Pratt (Fr.)
DT	52	DALLAS AFALAVA (SR.)	55	Kadear Dembele (Fr.)
DE	11	LANGSTON HARDY (SR.)	9	Camden Hardy (So.)
MLB	43	Frank Cusano (So.)	7	Buom Jock* (Jr.)
OLB	21	AIDEN HALL (SR.)	23	Vincent Firenze* (Jr.)
CB	2	Deuce Blades II* (Sr.)	27	TRAVON WEST (JR.)
CB	13	Ashaad Williams (Sr.)	4	Sascha Garcia (So.)
NB	5	DAVAUGHN PATTERSON (JR.)	17	Zamari Stevenson (Sr.)
S	6	Rushaun Tongue (So.)	22	Myles Turpin (So.)
S	8	BRAYLON JOHNSON (JR.)	25	Joshua Patterson* (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	90	Connor Calvert (So.)	KR	35	Koredell Bartley (So.)
P	45	Ethan Hyams (Fr.)	PR	5	Kam Shanks* (Jr.)

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